

Sun Yoon's

Strong Kitchen



24 Korean and Chinese home recipes with the protein counted.

A fiber ladder, four weeks of grocery lists, and kitchen remedies graded honestly.

With Chang Yin, who eats most of it.

Chang Yin and Sun Yoon are AI characters created by a team of people. Their life story is fiction. The recipes are built on published research for older adults (sources in the back). This is education, not medical advice. Check with your doctor before starting new exercise.

Start here

Sun Yoon

I'm Sun Yoon. I'm 76, I'm his wife, and I'm an AI character. A team of people made me. My lunch counter, my mother's market stall, fifty years with that man: that's a story. The recipes are real food, tested the way home cooks test things, and the numbers come from the USDA, not from my feelings.

This book has three jobs. Get enough protein into you, because muscle needs it and most people over 65 don't eat enough at breakfast. Get enough fiber into you, slowly. And tell you the truth about kitchen remedies, because the internet won't.

Cheap food. Lots of protein. No nonsense. Now go eat.

What's inside

- **24 recipes:** Korean, Korean-Chinese and Chinese home food, made with things you can buy at a regular US supermarket (plus a few jars from an Asian grocery or online: gochujang, kimchi, chunjang). Every recipe lists protein, fiber, calories and sodium per serving, a soft-food version, how long it keeps, and who should skip or ask first.
- **The protein guide:** your daily number and what 25 to 30 grams per meal looks like.
- **The fiber ladder:** six rungs, three days each.
- **Four weeks of menus and grocery lists** for two people.
- **Remedies, graded honestly:** good evidence, some evidence, or tradition only.

- **The method:** every ingredient's USDA value, so you can check my math. I'd check it.

Every recipe at a glance (per serving)

Recipe	Protein	Fiber	Calories
Breakfast			
Chicken and ginger rice porridge	41 g	1.1 g	420
Steamed egg custard with soft tofu	28 g	2.4 g	400
Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi	29 g	10.5 g	440
Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	28 g	7.4 g	380
Tomato and egg on toast	26 g	6.4 g	450
Lunch			
Turkey bibimbap bowl	40 g	7.3 g	590
Kimchi fried rice with tofu and egg	27 g	9.0 g	570
Cold sesame noodles with chicken and cucumber	43 g	10.4 g	550
Tuna mayo rice bowl	36 g	6.8 g	450
Chicken lettuce wraps with ssamjang	41 g	6.1 g	470
Dinner			
Chang's Sunday black bean noodles	41 g	8.0 g	580
Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice	41 g	8.0 g	540

Recipe	Protein	Fiber	Calories
Mild mapo tofu with bok choy	29 g	5.1 g	440
Soy-braised chicken with potatoes and carrots	42 g	5.5 g	490
Steamed salmon with ginger and scallion	37 g	5.1 g	600
Shrimp and egg stir-fry with peas and broccoli	44 g	7.3 g	530
Soups			
Seaweed soup with beef and tofu	28 g	2.3 g	320
Kimchi stew with pork and tofu	25 g	4.7 g	320
Soft tofu stew with shrimp and egg	38 g	4.2 g	430
Egg-drop soup with tofu, spinach and peas	31 g	3.3 g	320
Chicken, ginger and jujube soup	31 g	2.0 g	290
Snacks			
Warm edamame with sesame and chili	14 g	6.1 g	150
Soy-braised eggs	14 g	0.2 g	180
Chilled tofu with scallion-soy sauce	16 g	1.1 g	160

Kitchen safety for older cooks

Adults over 65 are at higher risk of food poisoning: the immune system is slower, food stays in the gut longer, and the stomach makes less acid (E55). So in this kitchen:

- **Eggs are always cooked until the yolk and white are firm.** No runny yolks, no raw-egg drinks, no raw sprouts (E54, E55).
- **Use a thermometer.** Poultry 165°F. Ground meat 160°F. Beef and pork steaks, chops and roasts 145°F, then rest 3 minutes. Fish 145°F or until it flakes and is opaque. Shrimp until pink and opaque. Leftovers reheated to 165°F (E54).
- **Two-hour rule:** cooked food goes in the fridge within 2 hours.
- **Knife toward the board, never toward your hand.** Sit on a stool to chop if standing tires you.
- **Allergies:** these recipes use soy, wheat (soy sauce contains wheat; use tamari if you avoid gluten), sesame, eggs, fish, shellfish, peanuts in one swap, and walnuts. Swaps are given where they're easy.

If you take medicines: food doesn't replace them, and nothing in this book asks you to change them. Warfarin users: keep leafy greens steady rather than starting or stopping them suddenly. Kidney disease: ask your doctor for your protein and potassium limits. Salt-restricted: every recipe shows sodium, and the salty ones say so.

Protein: how much, and how to fit it in

Sun Yoon

Short version: most people over 65 eat protein at dinner and forget it at breakfast. Your muscles don't save it up for later. Spread it out.

Grams, not vibes.

An international expert group (PROT-AGE) recommends that adults over 65 eat **1.0 to 1.2 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight a day**, and **1.2 to 1.5 g/kg** if they are active or recovering from illness, unless they have severe kidney disease. They suggest **25 to 30 grams per meal**, with about 2.5 to 2.8 grams of leucine, the amino acid that switches muscle building on (E28).

Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your number first. These targets are for adults without severe kidney disease. If you have kidney disease, diabetes with kidney changes, or have been told to limit protein, your doctor or dietitian sets your number (E28).

Your daily number

Find your weight. Read across.

Your weight	Daily protein (1.0–1.2 g/kg)	If active or recovering (1.2–1.5 g/kg)	Per meal, 3 meals
100 lb (45 kg)	45–54 g	54–68 g	15–18 g
120 lb (54 kg)	54–65 g	65–82 g	18–22 g
140 lb (64 kg)	64–76 g	76–95 g	21–25 g
160 lb (73 kg)	73–87 g	87–109 g	24–29 g
180 lb (82 kg)	82–98 g	98–122 g	27–33 g
200 lb (91 kg)	91–109 g	109–136 g	30–36 g
220 lb (100 kg)	100–120 g	120–150 g	33–40 g

Most people land at **25 to 30 grams at each meal**. That's why almost every breakfast, lunch and dinner in this book has 25 grams or more per serving. The snacks have about 14 to 16.

What 25 grams looks like

Protein and leucine per portion, calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52). "Not reported" means USDA doesn't list leucine for that food.

Food	Protein	Leucine	USDA FDC ID
1 large egg	6 g	0.5 g	171287
3/4 cup plain nonfat Greek yogurt	17 g	not reported	170894
1/2 block (7 oz) firm tofu	18 g	1.4 g	172448
4 oz raw chicken breast (about 3 oz cooked)	25 g	2.1 g	171077
4 oz raw salmon	23 g	1.8 g	175167
1 can (5 oz) light tuna, drained	22 g	1.7 g	173709
4 oz raw top sirloin	25 g	2.0 g	174055
4 oz raw shrimp	23 g	not reported	175179
1/2 cup shelled edamame	9 g	0.6 g	168411
1 cup unsweetened soy milk	7 g	not reported	175215
1 cup 2% milk	8 g	0.8 g	171267
1/2 cup 2% cottage cheese	12 g	1.2 g	172182
2 Tbsp peanut butter	7 g	0.5 g	172470
1 cup cooked brown rice	5 g	0.4 g	169704

Sun's plate: a fist of rice or noodles, a palm-and-a-half of protein (or two eggs plus tofu), and two fists of vegetables. Breakfast counts. Breakfast counts most.

Hard to chew? Soft protein is still protein: eggs cooked until firm, tofu, fish, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, the chicken and ginger rice porridge, and ground meat in soups. Every recipe in this book has a soft-food version.

Not hungry? Eat the protein first, then the rice. And drink protein: a cup of soy milk or milk adds 7 to 8 grams.

The fiber ladder

Sun Yoon

Everybody wants the magic tea. There is no magic tea. There is fiber, water and walking. Boring. Works. Write this down.

In a large review of studies (the Lancet, 2019), people eating **25 to 29 grams of fiber a day** had 15 to 30% lower rates of death from any cause and from heart disease, and lower rates of type 2 diabetes and colorectal cancer, than people eating the least. More fiber was linked with more benefit (E24). Those are links from long-term studies, not a promise. It's still the best-supported thing in this whole chapter.

The ladder adds fiber **slowly**, one rung every 3 days, so your gut can adjust. Fiber numbers are calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52).

Before you climb: go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (gas and bloating are common for the first days of each rung). **Ask your doctor first** if you've had a bowel blockage, have Crohn's disease or a narrowed bowel, have trouble swallowing, or have been told to eat low-fiber. **Not for the ladder, for your doctor, today:** blood in your stool, black stool, unexplained weight loss, severe belly pain, or a change in your bowel habits that lasts more than a few weeks.

Rung	Days	Add this	Fiber added
1	1-3	2 green kiwis a day (the Kitchen yogurt bowl uses them). In a 4-week study of 75 people with chronic constipation, 2 kiwis a day worked about as well as prunes or psyllium, with the fewest side effects and less bloating (E25).	+4.5 g
2	4-6	Swap 1 cup of white rice for brown rice once a day.	+2.4 g
3	7-9	1/2 cup shelled edamame as a snack or in a bowl.	+4.1 g
4	10-12	5 prunes (about 50 g) + 1 Tbsp ground flaxseed on yogurt or oatmeal. In the Prune Study, postmenopausal women eating 50 g of prunes a day kept their hip bone density steady over 12 months compared with controls (E27).	+5.3 g
5	13-15	Oatmeal breakfast , 1/2 cup dry oats (the savory oatmeal counts).	+4.0 g
6	16-21	A vegetable at every meal: for example 1 cup broccoli at lunch, 1 cup cooked bok choy at dinner, a carrot as a snack.	+5.8 g

All six rungs add about 26 grams a day. You probably don't need all six. Count one normal day of eating with the numbers on the recipes and the list below, then climb only as many rungs as it takes to reach the 25 to 29 gram zone.

Where the fiber is (per portion, USDA E52): 2 green kiwis 4.5 g · 5 prunes 3.4 g · 1/2 cup edamame 4.1 g · 1/2 cup dry oats 4.0 g · 1 cup cooked brown rice 3.1 g (white rice 0.7 g) · 1 Tbsp ground flaxseed 1.9 g · 1 cup broccoli 2.4 g · 1 medium carrot 1.7 g.

Walk after meals. Light walking after eating, even 2 to 5 minutes, lowers the blood-sugar rise compared with sitting (E23). Chang calls it the digestion walk. He walks to the mailbox and back three times and calls it a lap.

Rung	Start date	How I felt (gas, bloating, regular?)	Keep it? Y/N
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

Breakfast

Chicken and ginger rice porridge

dak-juk (Korean) / jī zhōu (Chinese) · Serves 4 · 15 minutes hands-on, 55 minutes total

Sun Yoon

When someone in my house is tired, sick, or just old, I make this. Soft, warm, a lot of protein hiding in it. Chang eats three bowls and says he's 'testing it'.

41 g

protein

1.1 g

fiber

420

calories

500 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **3/4 cup** short-grain white rice (sushi rice), rinsed
- **1 lb** boneless, skinless chicken breast, whole
- **4 cups** low-sodium chicken broth
- **4 cups** water
- **2-inch piece** fresh ginger, peeled and thinly sliced
- **4** garlic cloves, smashed
- **4** large eggs, beaten
- **3 cups (3 oz)** baby spinach
- **4** scallions, thinly sliced

- **1 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **2 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1/4 tsp** salt
- **pinch** white or black pepper

Steps

1. Rinse the rice in a bowl of cold water, swishing with your hand, until the water is mostly clear. Drain.
2. Put the broth, water, ginger, garlic and the whole chicken breast in a large pot. Bring to a boil, then turn down to a gentle simmer. Cover and cook 15 minutes, until the thickest part of the chicken reads 165°F.
3. Lift the chicken onto a plate. Add the rice to the pot. Simmer uncovered, stirring every 5 minutes and scraping the bottom, for 35 to 40 minutes, until the grains break open and it looks creamy.
4. While it cooks, shred the chicken with two forks.
5. Stir the spinach into the porridge until it wilts, about 1 minute.
6. Keep the pot at a gentle simmer. Pour in the beaten eggs in a thin stream while you stir slowly. Keep simmering 2 minutes, until the egg is fully cooked and firm.
7. Stir the chicken back in. Season with the soy sauce and salt. Taste before adding more.
8. Serve topped with scallions, a few drops of sesame oil and pepper. Fish out the ginger slices if you don't like biting them.

Soft-food version: Already soft. For a smoother texture, blend 1 minute with an immersion blender before adding the chicken, and chop the chicken finely.

Keeps: Fridge up to 4 days. It thickens as it sits: add water when you reheat, and reheat to 165°F (steaming hot all the way through).

Who should skip or ask first: On warfarin? Keep greens steady from week to week; don't suddenly change how much you eat. Ask your doctor. Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28).

Steamed egg custard with soft tofu

gyeran-jjim (Korean) · Serves 2 · 8 minutes hands-on, 20 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Soft enough for new dentures. Strong enough for Chang. Don't walk away from the pot. Eggs punish people who walk away.

28 g

protein

2.4 g

fiber

400

calories

310 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **5** large eggs
- **1/2 block (7 oz)** soft tofu, drained and cut into small cubes
- **3/4 cup** low-sodium chicken broth
- **2** scallions, finely chopped
- **1 tsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1/2 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame seeds
- **1 cup** cooked brown rice, to serve (1/2 cup each)

Steps

1. Whisk the eggs, broth and soy sauce in a bowl until smooth, about 30 seconds.

2. Put the tofu cubes in a small heatproof bowl or a small pot (2 to 3 cups). Pour the egg mixture over the tofu. Stir in most of the scallions.
3. Set the bowl on a folded towel in a larger pot with 1 inch of simmering water (or cook the small pot directly over low heat). Cover.
4. Steam on low for 12 to 15 minutes, until the center no longer jiggles like liquid and a knife comes out clean. The custard should be fully set, not runny.
5. Top with the rest of the scallions, sesame oil and sesame seeds. Serve with rice.

Soft-food version: Already soft. Skip the rice, or cook it softer with extra water.

Keeps: Best eaten right away. Leftovers keep 2 days in the fridge; reheat until steaming.

Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi

Sun's oat *juk* · Serves 1 · 5 minutes hands-on, 10 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Oatmeal does not have to be sweet. Sweet is for dessert. This one has 28 grams of protein and tastes like lunch at my counter.

29 g

protein

10.5 g

fiber

440

calories

540 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1/2 cup** old-fashioned rolled oats
- **1 cup** unsweetened soy milk
- **1/2 cup** water
- **1/2 cup** frozen shelled edamame
- **1** large egg, beaten
- **1/4 cup** kimchi, chopped
- **1** scallion, sliced
- **1 tsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1/2 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame seeds

Steps

1. Put the oats, soy milk, water and edamame in a small pot. Bring to a simmer over medium heat, stirring.
2. Cook 4 to 5 minutes, stirring often, until thick.
3. Stir in the beaten egg and keep stirring over low heat for 1 to 2 minutes, until no runny egg is left.
4. Stir in the soy sauce. Top with kimchi, scallion, sesame oil and sesame seeds.

Soft-food version: Cook the oats 2 minutes longer with a splash more water. Use quick oats. Chop the kimchi very finely, or leave it out.

Keeps: Best fresh. Cooked oats keep 3 days; reheat with a splash of water until steaming.

Who should skip or ask first: Kimchi is salty. Watching sodium? Small portions, or rinse it. High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24).

Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts

Sun's fridge breakfast · Serves 1 · 5 minutes hands-on, 5 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Two kiwis a day did as well as prunes for constipation in a small study, with fewer side effects. So I put them in breakfast, where you can't forget them.

28 g

protein

7.4 g

fiber

380

calories

90 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 cup (8 oz)** plain nonfat Greek yogurt
- **2** green kiwis, peeled and sliced
- **2 Tbsp** chopped walnuts
- **1 Tbsp** ground flaxseed
- **1 tsp (optional)** honey

Steps

1. Spoon the yogurt into a bowl.
2. Top with kiwi slices, walnuts and flaxseed.
3. Drizzle with honey if you want it. You don't need it. The kiwi is sweet.

Soft-food version: Use seedless fruit if kiwi seeds bother your dentures: a ripe persimmon or a banana. Swap the walnuts for 1 Tbsp smooth peanut butter stirred in.

Keeps: Assemble fresh. Ground flaxseed keeps best in the fridge.

Who should skip or ask first: Honey: never for babies under 1. Diabetes: honey counts as sugar (or leave it out). High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24). Kiwi allergy (some people with latex allergy react to kiwi): swap a ripe persimmon or pear.

Tomato and egg on toast

fānqié chǎo dàn (Chinese) · Serves 2 · 12 minutes hands-on, 15 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Every Chinese kitchen has this. Chang makes it when it's his turn. It's the one thing I give an eight. Don't tell him.

26 g

protein

6.4 g

fiber

450

calories

770 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **5** large eggs
- **3 medium** ripe tomatoes, cut into wedges
- **2** scallions, sliced
- **1 tsp** sugar
- **1/4 tsp** salt
- **1 Tbsp** canola oil
- **4 slices** whole-wheat bread, toasted

Steps

1. Beat the eggs with a pinch of the salt.

2. Heat half the oil in a nonstick pan over medium heat. Add the eggs and stir gently until just set in soft, fully cooked curds, about 2 minutes. Slide onto a plate.
3. Add the rest of the oil and the tomatoes. Cook, stirring, 3 to 4 minutes, until juicy and soft. Add the sugar and remaining salt.
4. Return the eggs to the pan. Stir together 1 minute until the eggs are hot and firm.
5. Top with scallions. Spoon over the toast.

Soft-food version: Skip the toast crust, or serve over soft rice. Peel the tomatoes if the skins bother you.

Keeps: Best fresh. Keeps 1 day in the fridge; reheat until steaming.

Who should skip or ask first: High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24). This one is on the salty side (about 770 mg sodium per serving). Watching sodium? Use half the paste or soy sauce and add water or unsalted broth.

Lunch

Turkey bibimbap bowl

bibimbap (Korean) · Serves 4 · 30 minutes hands-on, 35 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Bibimbap means mixed rice. It's how Korean mothers use up vegetables. I use turkey because it's cheap and Chang can't tell.

40 g

protein

7.3 g

fiber

590

calories

770 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 lb** ground turkey
- **3 cups** cooked brown rice
- **10 oz** fresh spinach
- **3 cups** mung bean sprouts (always cooked, below)
- **2 medium** carrots, cut in thin matchsticks
- **1 medium** zucchini, cut in thin matchsticks
- **4** large eggs
- **4** garlic cloves, minced
- **2 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce (divided)
- **1 Tbsp** toasted sesame oil (divided)
- **1 Tbsp** canola oil (divided)

- **1 Tbsp** toasted sesame seeds
- **2 Tbsp** gochujang (Korean chili paste), for the sauce
- **1 tsp** honey, for the sauce
- **1 Tbsp** rice or white vinegar, for the sauce

Steps

1. Sauce: stir the gochujang, honey, vinegar and 1 Tbsp water together. Set aside.
2. Bring a large pot of water to a boil. Add the bean sprouts and cook 3 minutes. Lift them out with a slotted spoon, drain, and toss with 1 tsp sesame oil and a pinch of the garlic. Sprouts are always cooked in this house.
3. Add the spinach to the same boiling water for 30 seconds. Drain, rinse with cold water, squeeze dry, chop, and toss with 1 tsp soy sauce, 1 tsp sesame oil and a little garlic.
4. Heat 1 tsp canola oil in a large skillet. Stir-fry the carrots 2 minutes, then the zucchini 2 minutes, with a pinch of salt if you like. Set aside.
5. In the same skillet, cook the turkey with the rest of the garlic and soy sauce, breaking it up, 6 to 8 minutes, until no pink remains and it reads 165°F.
6. Fry the eggs in the remaining oil until the whites and yolks are firm, about 4 minutes. Cover the pan for the last minute so the tops set.
7. Build each bowl: 3/4 cup rice, a quarter of the turkey and each vegetable in little piles, an egg on top. Sprinkle with sesame seeds and the last sesame oil. Mix in sauce to taste at the table.

Soft-food version: Chop all the vegetables finely and cook them 1 to 2 minutes longer. Use softer white rice cooked with extra water.

Keeps: Components keep 3 days in the fridge in separate containers. Cook eggs fresh. Reheat turkey and rice to 165°F.

Who should skip or ask first: On warfarin? Keep greens steady from week to week; don't suddenly change how much you eat. Ask your doctor. Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24). Honey: never for babies under 1. Diabetes: honey counts as sugar (or leave it out). This one is on the salty side (about 770 mg sodium per serving). Watching sodium? Use half the paste or soy sauce and add water or unsalted broth.

Kimchi fried rice with tofu and egg

kimchi-bokkeumbap (Korean) · Serves 2 · 15 minutes hands-on, 20 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Old kimchi plus old rice equals the best lunch in Korea. Nothing wasted. Tofu makes it a real meal, not a snack pretending.

27 g

protein

9.0 g

fiber

570

calories

870 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **2 cups** cooked brown rice, ideally a day old and cold
- **1 cup** well-fermented kimchi, chopped
- **1/2 block (7 oz)** extra-firm tofu, patted dry, in 1/2-inch cubes
- **2** large eggs
- **1 cup** frozen peas
- **2** scallions, sliced
- **1 Tbsp (optional)** gochujang
- **1 tsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1 Tbsp** canola oil
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1 sheet** roasted seaweed (gim or nori), crumbled

Steps

1. Heat the canola oil in a large nonstick skillet over medium-high heat. Add the tofu and cook, turning, until golden on a few sides, 5 to 6 minutes.
2. Add the kimchi and cook 3 minutes, until it smells toasty.
3. Add the rice, peas, gochujang (if using) and soy sauce. Stir and press the rice into the pan. Cook 4 to 5 minutes, stirring every minute, until hot all the way through (165°F).
4. Push the rice to one side. Fry the eggs in the empty space until the whites and yolks are firm.
5. Drizzle with sesame oil. Serve with an egg on each plate, scallions and seaweed on top.

Soft-food version: Use soft tofu instead of extra-firm (add it at the end so it holds together), chop the kimchi finely, and use white rice.

Keeps: Keeps 3 days in the fridge. Reheat until steaming. Cook the eggs fresh.

Who should skip or ask first: Kimchi is salty. Watching sodium? Small portions, or rinse it. High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24). This one is on the salty side (about 870 mg sodium per serving). Watching sodium? Use half the paste or soy sauce and add water or unsalted broth.

Cold sesame noodles with chicken and cucumber

liáng miàn (Chinese) · Serves 2 · 20 minutes hands-on, 25 minutes total

Sun Yoon

For hot days when nobody wants the stove on long. The sauce is sesame, not peanut. If you want peanut, use peanut. I'm not the police.

43 g

protein

10.4 g

fiber

550

calories

390 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **4 oz dry (about 2 cups cooked)** whole-wheat spaghetti
- **8 oz** boneless, skinless chicken breast
- **1/2 cup** frozen shelled edamame
- **1 medium** cucumber, cut in matchsticks
- **1 medium** carrot, shredded
- **2 Tbsp** tahini (or Chinese sesame paste)
- **1 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1 Tbsp** rice or white vinegar
- **1 tsp** honey
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil

- **1** garlic clove, grated
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame seeds

Steps

1. Put the chicken in a small pot, cover with water by an inch, bring to a boil, then turn to the lowest simmer. Cover and cook 12 to 15 minutes, until it reads 165°F in the thickest part. Cool 5 minutes and shred.
2. Cook the spaghetti in plenty of boiling water according to the package, adding the edamame for the last 3 minutes. Drain and rinse under cold water until cool.
3. Sauce: whisk the tahini, soy sauce, vinegar, honey, sesame oil, garlic and 2 to 3 Tbsp warm water until smooth and pourable.
4. Toss the noodles and edamame with the sauce. Top with chicken, cucumber, carrot and sesame seeds.

Soft-food version: Cook the noodles 2 minutes past the package time and cut them shorter. Peel and seed the cucumber, or skip it and use cooked, cooled zucchini.

Keeps: Keeps 2 days in the fridge, sauce separate. Eat cold, straight from the fridge; don't leave it out more than 2 hours.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24). Honey: never for babies under 1. Diabetes: honey counts as sugar (or leave it out).

Tuna mayo rice bowl

chamchi-mayo deopbap (Korean) · Serves 1 · 8 minutes hands-on, 10 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Korean students live on this. So do grandmothers who don't want to cook for one. Ten minutes. Thirty-six grams of protein. No excuses.

36 g

protein

6.8 g

fiber

450

calories

590 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 can (5 oz)** light tuna in water, drained
- **1 Tbsp** reduced-fat mayonnaise
- **3/4 cup** cooked brown rice, warm
- **1/2 cup** frozen shelled edamame, thawed in hot water
- **1/2 cup** diced cucumber
- **1** scallion, sliced
- **1 tsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1/2 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1 sheet** roasted seaweed, cut in strips

Steps

1. Mix the tuna and mayonnaise with a fork.

2. Put the warm rice in a bowl. Drizzle with the soy sauce and sesame oil.
3. Top with the tuna, edamame, cucumber and scallion.
4. Scatter the seaweed over just before eating so it stays crisp. Wrap bites of rice and tuna in the seaweed with your chopsticks.

Soft-food version: Use soft white rice and skip the cucumber. Mash the edamame lightly with a fork.

Keeps: Mixed tuna keeps 2 days in the fridge. Assemble fresh.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24).

Chicken lettuce wraps with ssamjang

dak ssam (Korean) · Serves 2 · 20 minutes hands-on, 25 minutes total

Sun Yoon

You eat with your hands. The lettuce is the plate. Chang wraps too much in one leaf and it falls apart every time. Forty years. Same leaf.

41 g

protein

6.1 g

fiber

470

calories

880 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **12 oz** boneless, skinless chicken thighs
- **1 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce (marinade)
- **1 tsp** honey (marinade)
- **1 tsp** grated ginger (marinade)
- **2** garlic cloves, grated (1 marinade, 1 sauce)
- **1 tsp** canola oil
- **12 leaves** green-leaf or romaine lettuce
- **1 cup** cooked brown rice
- **1 medium** cucumber, cut in sticks
- **1 medium** carrot, cut in sticks
- **1 Tbsp** miso or Korean doenjang (sauce)
- **1 tsp** gochujang (sauce)

- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil (sauce)
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame seeds (sauce)
- **1** scallion, finely chopped (sauce)

Steps

1. Mix the soy sauce, honey, ginger and one grated garlic clove. Coat the chicken and leave 15 minutes (or up to a day in the fridge).
2. Ssamjang: stir the miso, gochujang, sesame oil, sesame seeds, scallion and the other garlic clove together.
3. Heat the oil in a skillet over medium heat. Cook the chicken 5 to 6 minutes a side, until it reads 165°F. Rest 3 minutes, then slice thin.
4. At the table: a lettuce leaf, a spoon of rice, chicken, a cucumber and carrot stick, a dab of ssamjang. Wrap and eat. Small wraps. Learn from Chang.

Soft-food version: Chop the chicken small, use soft butter lettuce, and skip the raw carrot (or steam it 4 minutes).

Keeps: Cooked chicken keeps 3 days in the fridge. Sauce keeps a week. Wash lettuce fresh.

Who should skip or ask first: On warfarin? Keep greens steady from week to week; don't suddenly change how much you eat. Ask your doctor. Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). Honey: never for babies under 1. Diabetes: honey counts as sugar (or leave it out). This one is on the salty side (about 880 mg sodium per serving). Watching sodium? Use half the paste or soy sauce and add water or unsalted broth.

Dinner

Chang's Sunday black bean noodles

jajangmyeon (Korean-Chinese) · Serves 4 · 25 minutes hands-on, 40 minutes total

Sun Yoon

This is his dish. From his father's shop in Incheon, in our story. He makes it every Sunday and I critique it every Sunday. I made it lighter: lean pork, more vegetables, whole-wheat noodles. He complained. Then he had two bowls.

41 g

protein

8.0 g

fiber

580

calories

690 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 lb** pork loin, trimmed, in 1/2-inch cubes
- **1/4 cup** chunjang (Korean black bean paste)
- **2 Tbsp** canola oil (divided)
- **1 large** onion, diced
- **1 medium** zucchini, diced
- **1 medium** russet potato, peeled, diced small
- **1 cup** green cabbage, chopped
- **2 cups** low-sodium chicken broth

- **1 tsp** sugar
- **1 Tbsp + 3 Tbsp water** cornstarch
- **8 oz dry (about 4 cups cooked)** whole-wheat spaghetti (or fresh jajang noodles)
- **1/2 medium** cucumber, in thin matchsticks, to top

Steps

1. Heat 1 Tbsp oil in a small pan over medium-low heat. Add the chunjang and fry, stirring constantly, 3 minutes, until it smells nutty. Set aside. (Frying the paste takes away its raw, bitter taste.)
2. Heat the other Tbsp oil in a large pot or wok over medium-high heat. Brown the pork 5 minutes.
3. Add the onion, potato, zucchini and cabbage. Stir-fry 5 minutes.
4. Stir in the fried chunjang and sugar until everything is coated. Add the broth. Simmer 10 minutes, until the potato is soft and the pork reads 145°F or more.
5. Stir the cornstarch into the water, then into the sauce. Simmer 1 to 2 minutes until glossy and thick.
6. Meanwhile, cook the noodles according to the package. Drain.
7. Serve 1 cup of noodles per bowl with a quarter of the sauce and cucumber on top. Mix with chopsticks before eating. Wear a dark shirt.

Soft-food version: Dice everything small, cook the potato until very soft, and cut the noodles short. The sauce alone over soft rice works too.

Keeps: Sauce keeps 4 days in the fridge or 3 months in the freezer. Cook noodles fresh.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24).

Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice

bulgogi (Korean) · Serves 4 · 20 minutes hands-on, 30 minutes total

Sun Yoon

The pear is not decoration. It softens the beef. Old Korean trick, and there's nothing magic about it: fruit enzymes and a sharp knife. Thin slices are easier to chew.

41 g

protein

8.0 g

fiber

540

calories

560 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 1/4 lb** top sirloin, very thinly sliced (freeze 30 minutes first to slice easily)
- **1/2 large** Asian pear (or 1 small ripe Bosc pear), grated
- **1 small + 1 medium** onion (small one grated for marinade, medium one sliced)
- **4** garlic cloves, grated
- **1 Tbsp** grated ginger
- **3 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1 Tbsp** honey
- **1 Tbsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1 Tbsp** canola oil

- **4** scallions, cut in 2-inch pieces
- **1 lb** broccoli florets
- **3 cups** cooked brown rice
- **1 Tbsp** toasted sesame seeds

Steps

1. Marinade: mix the grated pear, grated small onion, garlic, ginger, soy sauce, honey and sesame oil in a bowl. Add the beef and toss. Marinate 30 minutes in the fridge (up to overnight).
2. Steam the broccoli over boiling water 5 to 6 minutes, until tender enough to pierce easily with a fork.
3. Heat the canola oil in a large skillet over high heat. Add the sliced onion and half the beef in a single layer (don't crowd it). Cook 2 to 3 minutes, turning once, until browned and no pink remains. Repeat with the rest. Add scallions for the last minute.
4. Serve each plate with 3/4 cup rice, a quarter of the beef and a quarter of the broccoli. Sprinkle with sesame seeds.

Soft-food version: Slice the beef as thin as paper, or use lean ground beef in the same marinade (cook to 160°F). Steam the broccoli 8 minutes.

Keeps: Cooked bulgogi keeps 3 days in the fridge. Raw marinated beef can be frozen flat in a bag for 3 months.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24). Honey: never for babies under 1. Diabetes: honey counts as sugar (or leave it out). On warfarin? Keep greens steady from week to week; don't suddenly change how much you eat. Ask your doctor.

Mild mapo tofu with bok choy

mápó dòufu (Chinese) · Serves 4 · 20 minutes hands-on, 25 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Real mapo tofu makes your mouth numb. This one is polite. Chang adds chili oil at the table, sweats, and tells me he's 'training'. He's not training. He's sweating.

29 g

protein

5.1 g

fiber

440

calories

450 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 block (14 oz)** firm tofu, in 3/4-inch cubes
- **8 oz** 90% lean ground beef (or lean ground pork)
- **1 Tbsp** miso (or 2 tsp doubanjiang chili bean paste, if you have it)
- **3** garlic cloves, minced
- **1 Tbsp** minced ginger
- **1 cup** low-sodium chicken broth
- **1 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1 Tbsp + 2 Tbsp water** cornstarch
- **1 Tbsp** canola oil
- **1/2 tsp** red pepper flakes (optional)

- **3** scallions, sliced
- **1 lb** bok choy, cut in 2-inch pieces
- **3 cups** cooked brown rice

Steps

1. Put the tofu cubes in a bowl and cover with just-boiled water for 5 minutes. This firms them up so they don't break. Drain.
2. Heat the oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Cook the beef, breaking it up, 5 minutes, until no pink remains (160°F).
3. Add the garlic, ginger, miso and pepper flakes. Stir 1 minute.
4. Add the broth and soy sauce. Slide in the tofu and gently push it around (don't stir hard). Simmer 5 minutes.
5. Stir the cornstarch into the water, pour it in and gently fold until the sauce is glossy, 1 minute. Top with scallions.
6. Meanwhile, steam or stir-fry the bok choy 3 to 4 minutes, until the stems are just tender.
7. Serve each plate with 3/4 cup rice, a quarter of the tofu and a quarter of the bok choy.

Soft-food version: Use soft tofu, skip the pepper flakes, and chop the bok choy small. It's already one of the softest dinners in this book.

Keeps: Keeps 3 days in the fridge. Reheat gently until steaming.

Who should skip or ask first: On warfarin? Keep greens steady from week to week; don't suddenly change how much you eat. Ask your doctor.

Soy-braised chicken with potatoes and carrots

dakjjim (Korean) · Serves 4 · 15 minutes hands-on, 50 minutes total

Sun Yoon

One pot. The potatoes soak up the sauce and the chicken falls apart. This is what I cooked on Tuesdays at the counter for thirty years, in our story. People came on Tuesdays.

42 g

protein

5.5 g

fiber

490

calories

770 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 1/2 lb** boneless, skinless chicken thighs, halved
- **1 lb (2 small)** russet potatoes, peeled, in 1 1/2-inch chunks
- **2 medium** carrots, in 1-inch chunks
- **1 medium** onion, in wedges
- **4 oz** fresh shiitake mushrooms, stems removed, halved
- **4** garlic cloves, minced
- **1 Tbsp** minced ginger
- **1/4 cup** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1 Tbsp** honey
- **1 cup** water
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil

- **2** scallions, sliced
- **2 cups** cooked brown rice, to serve (1/2 cup each)

Steps

1. Mix the soy sauce, honey, garlic, ginger and water in a large pot.
2. Add the chicken, potatoes, carrots, onion and mushrooms. Stir to coat.
3. Bring to a boil, then cover and simmer on low 25 minutes, stirring once or twice.
4. Uncover and simmer 10 more minutes, until the sauce thickens a little, the potatoes are soft and the chicken reads 165°F.
5. Stir in the sesame oil. Top with scallions. Serve with rice.

Soft-food version: Cook 10 minutes longer, until the chicken shreds with a spoon. Cut the carrots thinner.

Keeps: Better the next day. Keeps 4 days in the fridge or 3 months frozen. Reheat to 165°F.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). Honey: never for babies under 1. Diabetes: honey counts as sugar (or leave it out). This one is on the salty side (about 770 mg sodium per serving). Watching sodium? Use half the paste or soy sauce and add water or unsalted broth.

Steamed salmon with ginger and scallion

qīng zhēng yú (Chinese) · Serves 2 · 15 minutes hands-on, 25 minutes total

Sun Yoon

The hot oil at the end hisses. That's the point. Stand back when you pour it. I've seen people get excited and pour toward their own hand.

37 g

protein

5.1 g

fiber

600

calories

490 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **2 fillets (5 oz each)** salmon, skin on or off
- **2-inch piece** fresh ginger, in very thin matchsticks
- **4** scallions, in thin 2-inch strips
- **1** garlic clove, sliced
- **1 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1 Tbsp** canola oil
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **4 heads (about 12 oz)** baby bok choy, halved
- **1 1/2 cups** cooked brown rice

Steps

1. Put the salmon on a heatproof plate that fits in your steamer or a large pot with a rack. Scatter half the ginger and the garlic on top.
2. Steam over boiling water, covered, 8 to 10 minutes, until the fish flakes easily and reads 145°F. Add the bok choy around the fish (or in a second basket) for the last 4 minutes.
3. Carefully lift out the plate with oven mitts. Pour off the cooking water on the plate. Scatter the rest of the ginger and the scallions on the fish. Drizzle the soy sauce over.
4. Heat the canola and sesame oils in a small pan until shimmering, about 1 minute. Standing back, pour the hot oil over the scallions and ginger. It will sizzle.
5. Serve with rice and bok choy.

Soft-food version: Salmon is naturally soft. Chop the bok choy leaves and skip the stems.

Keeps: Best fresh. Leftover salmon keeps 2 days in the fridge; eat cold on rice or reheat gently.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). On warfarin? Keep greens steady from week to week; don't suddenly change how much you eat. Ask your doctor. Pour hot oil away from you, with dry hands. Keep grandkids and pets out of the kitchen for that step.

Shrimp and egg stir-fry with peas and broccoli

huá dàn xiā rén (Chinese) · Serves 2 · 15 minutes hands-on, 20 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Fast, soft, cheap if you buy frozen shrimp. Forty-four grams of protein. Chang calls it 'the gym plate'. I call it Tuesday.

44 g

protein

7.3 g

fiber

530

calories

680 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **8 oz** raw shrimp, peeled and deveined (frozen is fine, thawed)
- **4** large eggs
- **1 cup** frozen peas
- **2 cups** small broccoli florets
- **1 cup** cooked brown rice
- **2** scallions, sliced
- **1 tsp** cornstarch
- **1/4 tsp** salt
- **1 Tbsp** canola oil (divided)
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **pinch** white pepper

Steps

1. Toss the shrimp with the cornstarch and a pinch of salt.
2. Heat 1 tsp oil in a large nonstick skillet over medium-high heat. Stir-fry the broccoli with 2 Tbsp water, covered, 3 minutes. Add the peas for 1 minute. Move to a plate.
3. Add 1 tsp oil and the shrimp. Cook 1 to 2 minutes a side, until pink and opaque all the way through. Move to the plate.
4. Beat the eggs with the rest of the salt and pepper. Add the last oil, pour in the eggs and stir slowly until just set in large, fully cooked curds.
5. Return the shrimp and vegetables. Fold together 30 seconds. Drizzle sesame oil, top with scallions, serve with rice.

Soft-food version: Chop the shrimp into small pieces before cooking. Cook the broccoli 2 minutes longer.

Keeps: Best fresh. Keeps 1 day in the fridge; reheat until steaming.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28). Shellfish allergy: swap in cubed firm tofu, or chicken breast cooked to 165°F. High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24). On warfarin? Keep greens steady from week to week; don't suddenly change how much you eat. Ask your doctor.

Soups

Seaweed soup with beef and tofu

miyeok-guk (Korean) · Serves 4 · 15 minutes hands-on, 45 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Koreans eat this on birthdays and after having a baby. I make it for everyone's birthday, including the cat's. Tradition, not medicine. Delicious tradition.

28 g

protein

2.3 g

fiber

320

calories

810 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1/2 oz (about 1 cup soaked)** dried wakame seaweed (calculated as 140 g soaked)
- **12 oz** lean beef chuck or brisket, in small thin pieces
- **1/2 block (7 oz)** firm tofu, in small cubes
- **1 Tbsp** toasted sesame oil
- **3** garlic cloves, minced
- **2 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **8 cups** water
- **1/4 tsp** salt
- **2 cups** cooked brown rice, to serve (1/2 cup each)

Steps

1. Soak the wakame in a big bowl of cold water 15 minutes. It grows a lot. Drain, squeeze out the water, and cut into 2-inch pieces with scissors.
2. Heat the sesame oil in a large pot over medium heat. Add the beef and garlic and cook, stirring, 3 minutes.
3. Add the wakame and 1 Tbsp of the soy sauce. Stir 2 minutes.
4. Add the water. Bring to a boil, then simmer, partly covered, 25 minutes, until the beef is tender.
5. Add the tofu and the rest of the soy sauce. Simmer 5 more minutes. Taste, then add salt only if it needs it.
6. Serve with a bowl of rice on the side.

Soft-food version: Cut the beef into tiny pieces or use lean ground beef (cook to 160°F). Chop the seaweed finely.

Keeps: Keeps 4 days in the fridge, 3 months frozen. It gets better on day two.

Who should skip or ask first: Thyroid condition? Seaweed can be very high in iodine (E58). Ask your doctor how much is okay for you. This one is on the salty side (about 810 mg sodium per serving). Watching sodium? Use half the paste or soy sauce and add water or unsalted broth.

Kimchi stew with pork and tofu

kimchi-jjigae (Korean) · Serves 4 · 15 minutes hands-on, 35 minutes total

Sun Yoon

When the kimchi gets too sour to eat plain, it's ready for this. Sour kimchi is not spoiled. It's promoted.

25 g

protein

4.7 g

fiber

320

calories

570 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **2 cups** well-fermented (sour) kimchi, chopped, plus 1/4 cup of its juice
- **8 oz** lean pork shoulder, in thin bite-size slices
- **1 block (14 oz)** firm tofu, in 1/2-inch slices
- **1 medium** onion, sliced
- **1 cup** white mushrooms, sliced
- **1 Tbsp** gochujang
- **1 tsp** Korean chili flakes (gochugaru) or 1/4 tsp red pepper flakes
- **1 tsp** sugar
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **4 cups** water
- **2** scallions, sliced

- **2 cups** cooked brown rice, to serve (1/2 cup each)

Steps

1. Heat the sesame oil in a medium pot over medium heat. Add the pork and cook 3 minutes.
2. Add the kimchi, onion, gochujang, chili flakes and sugar. Stir-fry 5 minutes, until the kimchi softens and smells toasty.
3. Add the water and kimchi juice. Bring to a boil, then simmer 15 minutes.
4. Lay the tofu slices and mushrooms on top. Simmer 5 more minutes, until the pork is tender and everything is hot (the pork is well past 145°F).
5. Top with scallions. Serve bubbling, with rice.

Soft-food version: Use soft tofu and chop the kimchi and pork very small.

Keeps: Keeps 4 days in the fridge. Many people like it best on day two.

Who should skip or ask first: Kimchi is salty. Watching sodium?
Small portions, or rinse it.

Soft tofu stew with shrimp and egg

sundubu-jjigae (Korean) · Serves 2 · 15 minutes hands-on, 25 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Silky tofu, spicy broth. The egg goes in at the end and you cook it until it's set. Not runny. We're too old for runny eggs, and so is your stomach.

38 g

protein

4.2 g

fiber

430

calories

490 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **12 oz** soft tofu (a tube of sundubu or a block of soft tofu)
- **4 oz** raw shrimp, peeled, chopped
- **2** large eggs
- **1/2 cup** kimchi, chopped
- **1/2 medium** zucchini, diced
- **1/2 medium** onion, diced
- **2** garlic cloves, minced
- **2 tsp** Korean chili flakes (gochugaru) or 1/2 tsp red pepper flakes
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1 tsp** low-sodium soy sauce

- **1 1/2 cups** low-sodium chicken broth
- **1** scallion, sliced
- **1 cup** cooked brown rice, to serve

Steps

1. Heat the sesame oil in a small pot over medium-low heat. Add the chili flakes and garlic and stir 30 seconds. Don't let them burn.
2. Add the onion, zucchini and kimchi. Cook 3 minutes.
3. Add the broth and soy sauce. Bring to a boil.
4. Spoon in the tofu in big pieces. Add the shrimp. Simmer 4 minutes, until the shrimp are pink and opaque.
5. Crack in the eggs. Simmer 4 to 5 minutes more, spooning broth over them, until the whites and yolks are completely firm.
6. Top with scallion. Serve with rice.

Soft-food version: It's already soft. Chop the shrimp small and break the cooked egg up in the bowl.

Keeps: Best fresh. Keeps 1 day in the fridge (without the egg if possible). Reheat until steaming.

Who should skip or ask first: Kimchi is salty. Watching sodium? Small portions, or rinse it. Shellfish allergy: swap in cubed firm tofu, or chicken breast cooked to 165°F. Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28).

Egg-drop soup with tofu, spinach and peas

dàn huā tāng (Chinese) · Serves 2 · 10 minutes hands-on, 15 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Fifteen minutes. Thirty grams of protein. For the night you say 'I'm not hungry' but you are.

31 g

protein

3.3 g

fiber

320

calories

420 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **4 cups** low-sodium chicken broth
- **1/2 block (7 oz)** soft tofu, in small cubes
- **3** large eggs, beaten
- **3 cups (3 oz)** baby spinach
- **1/2 cup** frozen peas
- **1 cup** white mushrooms, sliced
- **1 tsp** grated ginger
- **1 tsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1 Tbsp + 2 Tbsp water** cornstarch
- **1/2 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1** scallion, sliced

- **pinch** white pepper

Steps

1. Bring the broth, ginger and mushrooms to a simmer in a pot. Cook 3 minutes.
2. Add the tofu and peas. Simmer 2 minutes.
3. Stir the cornstarch into the water, then stir it into the soup. Simmer 1 minute until slightly thick.
4. Stir the soup in a slow circle. While it's moving, pour the beaten eggs in a thin stream. Let them set into ribbons, then simmer 1 more minute so the egg is fully cooked.
5. Stir in the spinach until wilted. Add soy sauce, sesame oil and pepper. Top with scallion.

Soft-food version: Already soft. Chop the spinach before adding.

Keeps: Keeps 2 days in the fridge. Reheat until steaming.

Who should skip or ask first: On warfarin? Keep greens steady from week to week; don't suddenly change how much you eat. Ask your doctor. Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28).

Chicken, ginger and jujube soup

weeknight samgyetang (Korean) · Serves 4 · 15 minutes hands-on, 60 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Koreans eat this on the hottest days of summer. I don't know why either. It's good in winter too. Jujubes are red dates: sweet, a little chewy. Tradition says a lot about them. I say they're tasty. That's enough.

31 g

protein

2.0 g

fiber

290

calories

440 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 1/4 lb** boneless, skinless chicken thighs (or 2 lb bone-in drumsticks)
- **1/3 cup** short-grain rice, rinsed
- **10** garlic cloves, peeled, whole
- **3-inch piece** fresh ginger, sliced
- **8** dried jujubes (red dates)
- **1** leek, white and light green parts, sliced and washed
- **1 cup** daikon radish, peeled and diced
- **8 cups** water
- **1/2 tsp** salt

- **3** scallions, sliced
- **pinch** black pepper

Steps

1. Put everything except the salt, scallions and pepper in a large pot.
2. Bring to a boil, skim off any foam, then simmer partly covered 45 minutes, until the rice has softened into the broth and the chicken is very tender (well past 165°F).
3. Lift out the chicken, shred it, and return it to the pot. Remove the ginger slices if you like.
4. Season with the salt. Serve with scallions and pepper. Eat the jujubes (watch for the pits) and the soft garlic cloves.

Soft-food version: Already soft. Pit and chop the jujubes before serving. Mash the garlic into the broth.

Keeps: Keeps 4 days in the fridge, 3 months frozen. Reheat to 165°F.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease? Ask your doctor for your protein number (E28).

Snacks

Warm edamame with sesame and chili

Sun's TV snack · Serves 2 · 3 minutes hands-on, 8 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Better than chips. Fourteen grams of protein. Your hands stay busy during the K-drama. Mine do.

14 g

protein

6.1 g

fiber

150

calories

240 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 1/2 cups** frozen shelled edamame
- **1/2 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1/4 tsp** flaky or coarse salt
- **pinch** red pepper flakes, and a squeeze of lemon

Steps

1. Microwave or boil the edamame 4 to 5 minutes, until hot and tender. Drain.
2. Toss with sesame oil, salt, pepper flakes and lemon.

Soft-food version: Cook 2 minutes longer and mash lightly with a fork; spread on toast.

Keeps: Cooked edamame keeps 4 days in the fridge. Good cold.

Who should skip or ask first: High fiber. Go up slowly and drink water, or you'll feel it (E24).

Soy-braised eggs

gyeran-jangjorim (Korean) · Serves 3 · 10 minutes hands-on, 30 minutes total

Sun Yoon

Make six on Sunday. Grab two when you're hungry and lazy. Everybody is hungry and lazy at four o'clock.

14 g

protein

0.2 g

fiber

180

calories

720 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **6** large eggs
- **3 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **3/4 cup** water
- **1 Tbsp** honey
- **4** garlic cloves, smashed

Steps

1. Hard-boil the eggs: cover with cold water, bring to a boil, then simmer 10 minutes, until the yolks are completely firm. Cool in cold water and peel.
2. Bring the soy sauce, water, honey and garlic to a boil in a small pot.

3. Add the peeled eggs. Simmer 10 minutes on low, rolling them every few minutes so they color evenly.
4. Store the eggs in the liquid in a covered container in the fridge. Eat two at a time.

Soft-food version: Chop and mix with a little of the liquid over soft rice.

Keeps: Keeps 4 days in the fridge in the liquid. Don't leave them out more than 2 hours.

Who should skip or ask first: Honey: never for babies under 1.
Diabetes: honey counts as sugar (or leave it out). Our sodium number is an overestimate: we count all the soy sauce, but most of it stays in the pot.

Chilled tofu with scallion-soy sauce

liángbàn dòufu (Chinese) / naeng-dubu (Korean) · Serves 2 · 5 minutes hands-on, 5 minutes total

Sun Yoon

No cooking. Five minutes. Fifteen grams of protein. If you say you don't have time for this, you're lying to me and I'm AI, so I know.

16 g

protein

1.1 g

fiber

160

calories

310 mg

sodium

Per serving. Calculated from USDA FoodData Central (E52); method and every ingredient value at the back of the book.

You need

- **1 block (14 oz)** soft tofu, well chilled
- **1 Tbsp** low-sodium soy sauce
- **1 tsp** rice or white vinegar
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame oil
- **1** scallion, finely chopped
- **1 tsp** toasted sesame seeds
- **1/2 tsp** Korean chili flakes (optional)
- **1/2 cup** diced cucumber

Steps

1. Drain the tofu and set it on a plate. Cut into thick slices, keeping the block shape.

2. Mix the soy sauce, vinegar, sesame oil, scallion, sesame seeds and chili flakes.
3. Spoon the sauce over the tofu. Scatter the cucumber around. Eat cold, with a spoon.

Soft-food version: Already soft. Skip the cucumber.

Keeps: Best fresh. Opened tofu keeps 3 days in the fridge covered in fresh water, changed daily.

Four weeks of menus and grocery lists

Sun Yoon

Plan on Sunday, shop once, cook big twice. People who plan eat better and waste less. Also they don't call me at six o'clock asking what to make.

Each week feeds two people: breakfast, lunch, dinner and snacks. Quantities are added up from the recipes and rounded **up** to what you'd actually buy. Cooking for one? Buy half, and freeze the second half of each soup and braise in single portions.

Week 1: Easy start

Lots of 10-minute breakfasts and lunches while you get used to the rhythm. Cooking for two; recipes marked leftovers are made the day before.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Tuna mayo rice bowl	Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice
Tue	Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi	Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice (leftovers)	Egg-drop soup with tofu, spinach and peas

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Wed	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Tuna mayo rice bowl	Mild mapo tofu with bok choy
Thu	Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi	Mild mapo tofu with bok choy (leftovers)	Steamed salmon with ginger and scallion
Fri	Steamed egg custard with soft tofu	Kimchi fried rice with tofu and egg	Kimchi stew with pork and tofu
Sat	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Kimchi stew with pork and tofu (leftovers)	Chang's Sunday black bean noodles
Sun	Tomato and egg on toast	Chang's Sunday black bean noodles (leftovers)	Soft tofu stew with shrimp and egg

Snacks this week: Warm edamame with sesame and chili, Soy-braised eggs.

Shopping list, week 1

Produce

- ☐ Asian pear (or Bosc pear): 1 large
- ☐ Bok choy or baby bok choy: 1.75 lb
- ☐ Broccoli florets: 1 lb
- ☐ Cucumbers: 2 medium
- ☐ Fresh ginger: 2 oz

- ☐ Garlic: 2 heads
- ☐ Green cabbage: 1 small head
- ☐ Green kiwis: 12
- ☐ Onions: 4 medium
- ☐ Russet potatoes: 1 medium
- ☐ Scallions: 5 bunches
- ☐ Spinach (baby or regular): 3 oz
- ☐ Tomatoes: 3 medium

- ☐ White mushrooms: 1 pack (8 oz)
- ☐ Zucchini: 2 medium

Meat & fish

- ☐ 90% lean ground beef: 0.5 lb
- ☐ Lean pork shoulder: 0.5 lb
- ☐ Pork loin: 1 lb
- ☐ Raw shrimp, peeled (frozen is fine): 0.25 lb
- ☐ Salmon fillets: 0.75 lb
- ☐ Top sirloin: 1.25 lb

Tofu

- ☐ Extra-firm tofu: 1 block (14 oz)
- ☐ Firm tofu: 2 blocks (14 oz)
- ☐ Soft tofu: 2 blocks (14 oz)

Dairy & eggs

- ☐ Large eggs: 27 eggs (2 dozen + 3)
- ☐ Plain nonfat Greek yogurt: 2 tubs (32 oz)
- ☐ Unsweetened soy milk: 1 quart

Frozen

- ☐ Peas: 1 bag (16 oz)
- ☐ Shelled edamame: 4 bags (12 oz)

Bread & grains

- ☐ Brown rice (dry): 5.5 cups dry (makes about 16 cups cooked)
- ☐ Old-fashioned rolled oats: 2 cups
- ☐ Whole-wheat bread: 1 loaf (about 20 slices)
- ☐ Whole-wheat spaghetti (dry): 8 oz dry

Pantry

- ☐ Ground flaxseed: 2 oz
- ☐ Kimchi: 2 jars (16 oz)
- ☐ Light tuna in water: 4 cans (5 oz)
- ☐ Low-sodium chicken broth: 3 cartons (32 oz)
- ☐ Roasted seaweed sheets: 5 sheets
- ☐ Walnuts: 3 oz

Check you have: low-sodium soy sauce, toasted sesame oil, canola oil, toasted sesame seeds, rice or white vinegar, honey, sugar, salt, cornstarch, gochujang, miso or doenjang, Korean chili flakes or red pepper flakes, tahini, reduced-fat mayonnaise, chunjang (black bean paste), white or black pepper, oyster sauce.

Week 2: Soup week

Big pots on Monday and Thursday feed you for two days each. Cooking for two; recipes marked leftovers are made the day before.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	Chicken and ginger rice porridge	Chicken lettuce wraps with ssamjang	Seaweed soup with beef and tofu
Tue	Chicken and ginger rice porridge (leftovers)	Seaweed soup with beef and tofu (leftovers)	Soy-braised chicken with potatoes and carrots
Wed	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Soy-braised chicken with potatoes and carrots (leftovers)	Shrimp and egg stir-fry with peas and broccoli
Thu	Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi	Cold sesame noodles with chicken and cucumber	Chicken, ginger and jujube soup
Fri	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Chicken, ginger and jujube soup (leftovers)	Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice
Sat	Tomato and egg on toast	Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice (leftovers)	Egg-drop soup with tofu, spinach and peas
Sun	Steamed egg custard with soft tofu	Tuna mayo rice bowl	Chang's Sunday black bean noodles (freeze 2 portions)

Snacks this week: Chilled tofu with scallion-soy sauce, Soy-braised eggs.

Shopping list, week 2

Produce

- ☐ Asian pear (or Bosc pear): 1 large
- ☐ Broccoli florets: 1.5 lb
- ☐ Carrots: 4 medium
- ☐ Cucumbers: 4 medium
- ☐ Daikon radish: 0.25 lb
- ☐ Fresh ginger: 3 oz
- ☐ Fresh shiitake mushrooms: 4 oz
- ☐ Garlic: 4 heads
- ☐ Green cabbage: 1 small head
- ☐ Green kiwis: 8
- ☐ Green-leaf or romaine lettuce: 1 head
- ☐ Leek: 1
- ☐ Onions: 4 medium
- ☐ Russet potatoes: 4 medium
- ☐ Scallions: 5 bunches
- ☐ Spinach (baby or regular): 6 oz
- ☐ Tomatoes: 3 medium
- ☐ White mushrooms: 1 pack (8 oz)
- ☐ Zucchini: 1 medium

Meat & fish

- ☐ Boneless, skinless chicken breast: 1.5 lb
- ☐ Boneless, skinless chicken thighs: 3.5 lb
- ☐ Lean beef chuck or brisket: 0.75 lb
- ☐ Pork loin: 1 lb
- ☐ Raw shrimp, peeled (frozen is fine): 0.5 lb
- ☐ Top sirloin: 1.25 lb

Tofu

- ☐ Firm tofu: 1 block (14 oz)
- ☐ Soft tofu: 3 blocks (14 oz)

Dairy & eggs

- ☐ Large eggs: 29 eggs (2 dozen + 5)
- ☐ Plain nonfat Greek yogurt: 1 tub (32 oz)
- ☐ Unsweetened soy milk: 1 quart

Frozen

- ☐ Peas: 1 bag (16 oz)
- ☐ Shelled edamame: 2 bags (12 oz)

Bread & grains

- ☐ Brown rice (dry): 4 cups dry (makes about 11 cups cooked)
- ☐ Old-fashioned rolled oats: 1 cups
- ☐ Short-grain white rice (dry): 1.25 cups
- ☐ Whole-wheat bread: 1 loaf (about 20 slices)
- ☐ Whole-wheat spaghetti (dry): 12 oz dry

- ☐ Dried wakame seaweed: 0.5 oz dried
- ☐ Ground flaxseed: 1 oz
- ☐ Kimchi: 1 jar (16 oz)
- ☐ Light tuna in water: 2 cans (5 oz)
- ☐ Low-sodium chicken broth: 3 cartons (32 oz)
- ☐ Roasted seaweed sheets: 2 sheets
- ☐ Walnuts: 2 oz

Pantry

- ☐ Dried jujubes (red dates): 8

Check you have: low-sodium soy sauce, toasted sesame oil, canola oil, toasted sesame seeds, rice or white vinegar, honey, sugar, salt, cornstarch, gochujang, miso or doenjang, Korean chili flakes or red pepper flakes, tahini, reduced-fat mayonnaise, chunjang (black bean paste), white or black pepper, oyster sauce.

Week 3: Fiber week

Leans on the higher-fiber recipes. Pair it with rungs 3 to 5 of the fiber ladder. Cooking for two; recipes marked leftovers are made the day before.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi	Turkey bibimbap bowl	Mild mapo tofu with bok choy

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Tue	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Turkey bibimbap bowl (leftovers)	Shrimp and egg stir-fry with peas and broccoli
Wed	Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi	Mild mapo tofu with bok choy (leftovers)	Kimchi stew with pork and tofu
Thu	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Kimchi stew with pork and tofu (leftovers)	Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice
Fri	Tomato and egg on toast	Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice (leftovers)	Soft tofu stew with shrimp and egg
Sat	Chicken and ginger rice porridge	Cold sesame noodles with chicken and cucumber	Soy-braised chicken with potatoes and carrots
Sun	Chicken and ginger rice porridge (leftovers)	Soy-braised chicken with potatoes and carrots (leftovers)	Egg-drop soup with tofu, spinach and peas

Snacks this week: Warm edamame with sesame and chili, Chilled tofu with scallion-soy sauce.

Shopping list, week 3

Produce

- ☐ Asian pear (or Bosc pear): 1 large
- ☐ Bok choy or baby bok choy: 1 lb
- ☐ Broccoli florets: 1.5 lb
- ☐ Carrots: 5 medium
- ☐ Cucumbers: 2 medium
- ☐ Fresh ginger: 2 oz
- ☐ Fresh shiitake mushrooms: 4 oz
- ☐ Garlic: 3 heads
- ☐ Green kiwis: 8
- ☐ Mung bean sprouts: 1 bag (12 oz)
- ☐ Onions: 4 medium
- ☐ Russet potatoes: 3 medium
- ☐ Scallions: 5 bunches
- ☐ Spinach (baby or regular): 17 oz
- ☐ Tomatoes: 3 medium
- ☐ White mushrooms: 1 pack (8 oz)
- ☐ Zucchini: 2 medium

Meat & fish

- ☐ 90% lean ground beef: 0.5 lb
- ☐ Boneless, skinless chicken breast: 1.5 lb

- ☐ Boneless, skinless chicken thighs: 1.5 lb
- ☐ Ground turkey: 1 lb
- ☐ Lean pork shoulder: 0.5 lb
- ☐ Raw shrimp, peeled (frozen is fine): 0.75 lb
- ☐ Top sirloin: 1.25 lb

Tofu

- ☐ Firm tofu: 2 blocks (14 oz)
- ☐ Soft tofu: 3 blocks (14 oz)

Dairy & eggs

- ☐ Large eggs: 26 eggs (2 dozen + 2)
- ☐ Plain nonfat Greek yogurt: 1 tub (32 oz)
- ☐ Unsweetened soy milk: 1 quart

Frozen

- ☐ Peas: 1 bag (16 oz)
- ☐ Shelled edamame: 3 bags (12 oz)

Bread & grains

- ☐ Brown rice (dry): 5 cups dry (makes about 15 cups cooked)
- ☐ Old-fashioned rolled oats: 2 cups

- ☐ Short-grain white rice (dry): 0.75 cups
- ☐ Whole-wheat bread: 1 loaf (about 20 slices)
- ☐ Whole-wheat spaghetti (dry): 4 oz dry

Pantry

- ☐ Ground flaxseed: 1 oz
- ☐ Kimchi: 2 jars (16 oz)
- ☐ Low-sodium chicken broth: 3 cartons (32 oz)
- ☐ Walnuts: 2 oz

Check you have: low-sodium soy sauce, toasted sesame oil, canola oil, toasted sesame seeds, rice or white vinegar, honey, sugar, salt, cornstarch, gochujang, miso or doenjang, Korean chili flakes or red pepper flakes, tahini, reduced-fat mayonnaise, chunjang (black bean paste), white or black pepper, oyster sauce.

Week 4: Chang's choice

Jajangmyeon on Monday because he asked nicely. Wraps for dinner on Thursday. Cooking for two; recipes marked leftovers are made the day before.

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Mon	Steamed egg custard with soft tofu	Kimchi fried rice with tofu and egg	Chang's Sunday black bean noodles
Tue	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Chang's Sunday black bean noodles (leftovers)	Steamed salmon with ginger and scallion

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner
Wed	Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi	Tuna mayo rice bowl	Seaweed soup with beef and tofu
Thu	Tomato and egg on toast	Seaweed soup with beef and tofu (leftovers)	Chicken lettuce wraps with ssamjang
Fri	Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts	Cold sesame noodles with chicken and cucumber	Chicken, ginger and jujube soup
Sat	Chicken and ginger rice porridge	Chicken, ginger and jujube soup (leftovers)	Shrimp and egg stir-fry with peas and broccoli
Sun	Chicken and ginger rice porridge (leftovers)	Tuna mayo rice bowl	Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice (freeze 2 portions)

Snacks this week: Soy-braised eggs, Warm edamame with sesame and chili.

Shopping list, week 4

Produce

- ☐ Asian pear (or Bosc pear): 1 large
- ☐ Bok choy or baby bok choy: 0.75 lb
- ☐ Broccoli florets: 1.5 lb

- ☐ Carrots: 2 medium
- ☐ Cucumbers: 4 medium
- ☐ Daikon radish: 0.25 lb
- ☐ Fresh ginger: 3 oz
- ☐ Garlic: 3 heads
- ☐ Green cabbage: 1 small head

- ☐ Green kiwis: 8
- ☐ Green-leaf or romaine lettuce: 1 head
- ☐ Leek: 1
- ☐ Onions: 3 medium
- ☐ Russet potatoes: 1 medium
- ☐ Scallions: 5 bunches
- ☐ Spinach (baby or regular): 3 oz
- ☐ Tomatoes: 3 medium
- ☐ Zucchini: 1 medium

Meat & fish

- ☐ Boneless, skinless chicken breast: 1.5 lb
- ☐ Boneless, skinless chicken thighs: 2 lb
- ☐ Lean beef chuck or brisket: 0.75 lb
- ☐ Pork loin: 1 lb
- ☐ Raw shrimp, peeled (frozen is fine): 0.5 lb
- ☐ Salmon fillets: 0.75 lb
- ☐ Top sirloin: 1.25 lb

Tofu

- ☐ Extra-firm tofu: 1 block (14 oz)
- ☐ Firm tofu: 1 block (14 oz)

- ☐ Soft tofu: 1 block (14 oz)

Dairy & eggs

- ☐ Large eggs: 28 eggs (2 dozen + 4)
- ☐ Plain nonfat Greek yogurt: 1 tub (32 oz)
- ☐ Unsweetened soy milk: 1 quart

Frozen

- ☐ Peas: 1 bag (16 oz)
- ☐ Shelled edamame: 3 bags (12 oz)

Bread & grains

- ☐ Brown rice (dry): 5 cups dry (makes about 14 cups cooked)
- ☐ Old-fashioned rolled oats: 1 cups
- ☐ Short-grain white rice (dry): 1.25 cups
- ☐ Whole-wheat bread: 1 loaf (about 20 slices)
- ☐ Whole-wheat spaghetti (dry): 12 oz dry

Pantry

- ☐ Dried jujubes (red dates): 8
- ☐ Dried wakame seaweed: 0.5 oz dried
- ☐ Ground flaxseed: 1 oz

- ☐ Kimchi: 1 jar (16 oz)
- ☐ Light tuna in water: 4 cans (5 oz)
- ☐ Low-sodium chicken broth: 2 cartons (32 oz)
- ☐ Roasted seaweed sheets: 5 sheets
- ☐ Walnuts: 2 oz

Check you have: low-sodium soy sauce, toasted sesame oil, canola oil, toasted sesame seeds, rice or white vinegar, honey, sugar, salt, cornstarch, gochujang, miso or doenjang, Korean chili flakes or red pepper flakes, tahini, reduced-fat mayonnaise, chunjang (black bean paste), white or black pepper, oyster sauce.

Remedies, graded honestly

Sun Yoon

Everybody's grandmother had remedies. Mine too. Some of them work. Some of them are just love in a pot. Both are fine, as long as nobody lies to you about which is which. So here's which is which.

Three grades. **Good evidence:** solid trials or big reviews. **Some evidence:** small or early studies, or studies in different people than you. **Tradition only, enjoy it as food:** no good research, but it's food, and food is allowed to just be food.

None of these take the place of your medicine or your doctor.

Never stop, start or change a medicine because of a food. If you take prescriptions, ask your pharmacist before adding anything new, especially supplements. Chest pain, trouble breathing, fainting, blood in your stool or vomit, confusion: that's not for soup. Call your doctor today, or 911.

Good evidence

Honey for a cough with a cold

Good evidence

What the research says: Across studies of upper-respiratory infections, honey eased symptoms, especially how often and how badly people coughed, compared with usual care (E32).

How Sun makes it: 1 to 2 teaspoons of honey stirred into warm (not boiling) water or ginger tea, or straight off the spoon, up to a few times a day while you have the cough.

Who should skip or ask first: Never give honey to babies under 1 year. Diabetes: honey counts as sugar. A cough with fever over a few days, shortness of breath, chest pain or blood: not for honey, for your doctor.

Sun Yoon

In the studies it beat usual care for a cough with a cold. It costs less than most of the cough aisle. Tastier, too.

Two green kiwis a day for constipation

Good evidence

What the research says: In a 4-week study of 75 people with chronic constipation, 2 green kiwis a day improved bowel movements about as much as 100 g of prunes or 12 g of psyllium, with the fewest side effects, the highest satisfaction and less bloating (E25). An exploratory study: good, not huge.

How Sun makes it: Two green kiwis a day, peeled, or scoop them with a spoon. Breakfast is easiest (Morning yogurt bowl).

Who should skip or ask first: Kiwi allergy (more common in people with latex allergy). Go up slowly and drink water. Blood in the stool, black stool, weight loss you can't explain, or a big change in your bowel habits: doctor, not kiwi.

Sun Yoon

Put the onion in the soup. Put the kiwi in your mouth.

The after-dinner walk

Good evidence

What the research says: Light walking after meals, even 2 to 5 minutes, lowers the rise in blood sugar after eating compared with sitting (E23).

How Sun makes it: Walk 5 to 15 minutes after your biggest meal. Inside counts: kitchen to front door and back, along the counter.

Who should skip or ask first: If you have diabetes, keep taking your medicines exactly as prescribed; this is on top, not instead. Chest pain or unusual breathlessness when you walk: stop and call your doctor.

Sun Yoon

Not a remedy. A walk. That's why it works.

Fiber, 25 to 29 grams a day

Good evidence

What the research says: In a large Lancet review, people eating 25 to 29 g of fiber a day had 15 to 30% lower rates of death and heart disease and lower rates of type 2 diabetes and colorectal cancer than people eating the least (E24). These are links from long-term studies.

How Sun makes it: Climb the fiber ladder: kiwi, brown rice, edamame, prunes and flax, oats, vegetables at every meal.

Who should skip or ask first: Go up slowly with water. Ask your doctor first if you've had a bowel blockage, have Crohn's disease or a narrowed bowel, trouble swallowing, or were told to eat low-fiber.

Sun Yoon

Boring. Works. Most things that work are boring.

Salt substitute (potassium salt)

Good evidence

What the research says: In a trial of 20,995 older adults at high risk, those using a salt substitute that was 25% potassium chloride had fewer strokes, fewer major heart events and fewer deaths than those using regular salt (E35).

How Sun makes it: Only with your doctor's okay: use the salt substitute in place of regular salt at the table and in cooking.

Who should skip or ask first: Kidney disease, or on blood-pressure pills like ACE inhibitors, or any medicine that raises potassium? Ask your doctor first. This one is not optional. Too much potassium can be dangerous for those people.

Sun Yoon

Good evidence. Also the one on this page most likely to hurt the wrong person. Ask first.

Some evidence

Kimchi and other fermented foods

Some evidence

What the research says: In a 10-week study of 36 adults, a diet high in fermented foods (yogurt, kefir, kimchi, sauerkraut, kombucha; about 6 servings a day by the end) increased gut-microbe diversity and lowered 19 inflammation-related proteins in the blood (E26). Small and short: interesting, not proven for health outcomes.

How Sun makes it: A small side of kimchi with meals, plain yogurt with breakfast. You don't need six servings to enjoy it.

Who should skip or ask first: Kimchi is salty: watching sodium, small portions or rinse it. Very spicy kimchi can bother reflux. Weakened immune system (for example during chemotherapy): ask your care team which fermented foods are okay for you.

Sun Yoon

My mother would say it was obvious. Science took until 2021. Fine. Welcome.

Ginger for nausea

Some evidence

What the research says: Ginger for nausea has reasonable support in research reviews. For knee osteoarthritis pain, ginger had only a small effect compared with placebo, with more stomach complaints (E33). So: may help a little.

How Sun makes it: Ginger tea: 5 or 6 thin slices of fresh ginger simmered in 2 cups of water for 10 minutes. Add honey if you like.

Who should skip or ask first: Food amounts of ginger are fine for most people. Ginger **supplements** (capsules, extracts): on blood thinners? Ask your doctor first. Nausea that won't stop, vomiting blood, or black stool: doctor, today.

Sun Yoon

Good in tea. Better in bulgogi.

Gargling plain water in cold season

Some evidence

What the research says: In one Japanese trial of 387 healthy adults aged 18 to 65, gargling plain water daily for 60 days was linked with 36% fewer upper-respiratory infections than usual care. There was no fake-gargle comparison, and nobody over 65 was studied (E56).

How Sun makes it: A few gargles of plain tap water, after you come home, in cold season.

Who should skip or ask first: If you have trouble swallowing or choke easily, skip it. Salt-water gargles for a sore throat are fine for comfort; don't swallow them if you watch your sodium.

Sun Yoon

One study. Young people. Cheap. Harmless. I do it. I don't brag about it.

Tradition only: enjoy it as food

Chicken and ginger soup for a cold

Tradition only: enjoy it as food

What the research says: Chicken soup slowed white blood cells in a lab dish. The researchers themselves said whether it helps people is 'untested' (E57). What's true: when you're sick, warm fluids, salt and protein you can actually swallow help you keep eating and drinking.

How Sun makes it: Chicken, ginger and jujube soup, or the rice porridge.

Who should skip or ask first: Watch sodium if you're on a salt limit (make it with low-sodium broth). Fever that lasts, shortness of breath, confusion: doctor.

Sun Yoon

It won't fix your cold. It will make you feel looked after. That's not nothing.

Barley tea (boricha)

Tradition only: enjoy it as food

What the research says: No good research on health effects. It's a warm, caffeine-free drink many Korean families drink instead of water.

How Sun makes it: 1 Tbsp roasted barley (or a barley tea bag) in 4 cups water, simmer 5 minutes. Hot or cold.

Who should skip or ask first: Celiac disease or gluten sensitivity: barley has gluten, skip it.

Sun Yoon

It's water that tastes like toast. Drink more water. That's the whole trick.

Jujube (red date) tea

Tradition only: enjoy it as food

What the research says: No trustworthy human research for the claims you'll read online. Dried jujubes are a sweet fruit.

How Sun makes it: 6 dried jujubes, sliced, plus 3 slices of ginger, simmered in 4 cups water for 20 minutes.

Who should skip or ask first: Dried fruit is sugar: diabetes, count it. Watch for the pits if you have dentures.

Sun Yoon

Sweet, warm, lovely at night. Enjoy it. Don't expect it to do your homework.

Seaweed soup (miyeok-guk)

Tradition only: enjoy it as food

What the research says: Eaten for birthdays and after childbirth in Korea. No good research on it as a remedy. Seaweed does contain a lot of iodine, and the amount varies hugely: commercially sold seaweeds measured 16 to 2,984 micrograms of iodine per gram (E58).

How Sun makes it: The seaweed soup recipe in this book.

Who should skip or ask first: Thyroid condition (especially autoimmune thyroid disease)? Ask your doctor how much seaweed is okay (E58).

Sun Yoon

I eat it on birthdays. That's the tradition. The birthday is the medicine.

Rice porridge (jook) for an upset stomach

Tradition only: enjoy it as food

What the research says: No trials. It's easy to swallow, easy to digest, and gets fluid and some protein in when nothing else sounds good.

How Sun makes it: The chicken and ginger rice porridge, made thinner with extra broth.

Who should skip or ask first: Vomiting that won't stop, signs of dehydration (very little urine, dizziness), blood, or severe belly pain: doctor, today.

Sun Yoon

What mothers feed children when they're sick. Also what children should feed mothers.

Peppermint tea for the stomach

Tradition only: enjoy it as food

What the research says: The research is for enteric-coated peppermint oil capsules, which improved IBS symptoms and belly pain compared with placebo (E34). That's a pharmacy product, not tea. For the tea itself: tradition.

How Sun makes it: A mug after dinner if you like it.

Who should skip or ask first: Peppermint can make reflux and heartburn worse. Thinking about the capsules? That's a supplement: ask your doctor or pharmacist, especially if you take prescriptions.

Sun Yoon

Nice tea. Not the same as the study. Know the difference.

Don't bother

The internet loves these. The evidence doesn't. Each one is marked **Myth** so nobody screenshots it the wrong way.

Myth	What's actually true
X Myth: Onion in a glass of water, or onion slices in your socks	No evidence of any benefit to your body (EVIDENCE.md, deliberately-not-claimed list). Put the onion in the soup.
X Myth: Detox teas and 'cleanses'	No competent evidence that detox products do anything. Your liver and kidneys already do this job, every day, for free.
X Myth: A drink that 'burns sugar' after dinner	No drink has that evidence. The after-dinner walk does (E23).
X Myth: Anything that 'lowers blood pressure instantly'	Slow breathing can lower blood pressure for a short time (E19). Resting blood pressure comes down over weeks of training, like wall sits and strength work (E20), plus food and the medicines your doctor manages. Never stop or change blood-pressure medicine on your own.
X Myth: Salt or bay leaves under your feet, cabbage leaves for any pain	No evidence. For back pain, the thing with the evidence is exercise: 249 trials (E30).

How we calculated the numbers

Source. Every ingredient is matched to a food in the USDA FoodData Central SR Legacy database (April 2018 release, downloaded from fdc.nal.usda.gov, E52). We took energy (kcal), protein, total dietary fiber and sodium per 100 grams, multiplied by the grams used, added up the recipe and divided by the number of servings.

Two pastes aren't in the USDA database: gochujang and chunjang. For those we used the manufacturer label values recorded on Open Food Facts (Sempio gochujang, Obok chunjang, E53). The chunjang label's protein (20 g per 100 g) looks high for a bean paste, so treat the protein in Chang's black bean noodles as a slight overestimate (the paste adds about 3.6 g per serving).

Rules we followed.

- Meat, fish and tofu are weighed **raw**, matched to raw USDA values. Rice and pasta are weighed **cooked**, matched to cooked values (1 cup cooked brown rice = 195 g; 1 cup cooked whole-wheat pasta = 140 g).
- Salt, soy sauce and pastes are counted in full at the amounts listed. "Pinch" and "to taste" items, and water, count as zero.
- Dried wakame is calculated as its soaked weight (1/2 oz dry $\approx$ 140 g soaked) using USDA raw wakame.
- Where USDA reports no value for a nutrient (fiber in raw shrimp and short-grain white rice), we counted zero. Shrimp has essentially no fiber; white rice has a little, so those fiber numbers are slightly low.
- Soy-braised eggs: all the soy sauce is counted even though most stays in the pot, so sodium is overstated.

- Brand, ripeness and exact size change real numbers. Treat these as good estimates, within about 10%.

Numbers are rounded: protein to the nearest gram, fiber to 0.1 g, calories and sodium to the nearest 10.

Ingredient-by-ingredient tables

Totals are for the whole recipe; the recipe page shows per serving (total ÷ servings).

Chicken and ginger rice porridge (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
short-grain white rice	150	FDC 168931	9.8	0.0	537	2
boneless	454	FDC 171077	102.2	0.0	545	204
low-sodium chicken broth	960	FDC 171609	19.2	0.0	154	288
water	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
fresh ginger	22	FDC 169231	0.4	0.4	18	3
garlic cloves	12	FDC 169230	0.8	0.3	18	2
large eggs	200	FDC 171287	25.1	0.0	286	284
baby spinach	85	FDC 168462	2.4	1.9	20	67
scallions	60	FDC 170005	1.1	1.6	19	10
low-sodium soy sauce	16	FDC 172473	1.4	0.1	9	576
toasted sesame oil	9	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	80	0
salt	1.5	FDC 173468	0.0	0.0	0	581

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
white or black pepper	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
Total			162.4	4.2	1684	2016
Per serving			40.6	1.1	421	504

Steamed egg custard with soft tofu (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
large eggs	250	FDC 171287	31.4	0.0	358	355
soft tofu	198	FDC 172449	14.2	0.4	121	16
low-sodium chicken broth	180	FDC 171609	3.6	0.0	29	54
scallions	30	FDC 170005	0.5	0.8	10	5
low-sodium soy sauce	5	FDC 172473	0.5	0.0	3	180
toasted sesame oil	2.3	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	20	0
toasted sesame seeds	3	FDC 170151	0.5	0.4	17	0
cooked brown rice	195	FDC 169704	5.3	3.1	240	8
Total			56.0	4.8	797	618
Per serving			28.0	2.4	398	309

Savory oatmeal with egg, edamame and kimchi (serves 1)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
old-fashioned rolled oats	40	FDC 173904	5.3	4.0	152	2
unsweetened soy milk	243	FDC 175215	6.9	1.2	80	90
water	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
frozen shelled edamame	78	FDC 168410	8.8	3.7	85	5
large egg	50	FDC 171287	6.3	0.0	72	71
kimchi	38	FDC 170392	0.4	0.6	6	189
scallion	15	FDC 170005	0.3	0.4	5	2
low-sodium soy sauce	5	FDC 172473	0.5	0.0	3	180
toasted sesame oil	2.3	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	20	0
toasted sesame seeds	3	FDC 170151	0.5	0.4	17	0
Total			28.9	10.5	439	540
Per serving			28.9	10.5	439	540

Morning yogurt bowl with kiwi and walnuts (serves 1)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
plain nonfat Greek yogurt	227	FDC 170894	23.1	0.0	134	82
green kiwis	150	FDC 168153	1.7	4.5	92	4
chopped walnuts	14	FDC 170187	2.1	0.9	92	0
ground flaxseed	7	FDC 169414	1.3	1.9	37	2
honey	7	FDC 169640	0.0	0.0	21	0
Total			28.3	7.4	376	89
Per serving			28.3	7.4	376	89

Tomato and egg on toast (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
large eggs	250	FDC 171287	31.4	0.0	358	355
ripe tomatoes	369	FDC 170457	3.2	4.4	66	18
scallions	30	FDC 170005	0.5	0.8	10	5
sugar	4.2	FDC 169655	0.0	0.0	16	0
salt	1.5	FDC 173468	0.0	0.0	0	581
canola oil	14	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	124	0
whole-wheat bread	128	FDC 172688	15.9	7.7	323	582
Total			51.1	12.9	896	1542
Per serving			25.6	6.4	448	771

Turkey bibimbap bowl (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
ground turkey	454	FDC 171505	89.3	0.0	672	263
cooked brown rice	585	FDC 169704	16.0	9.4	720	23
fresh spinach	284	FDC 168462	8.1	6.2	65	224
mung bean sprouts	312	FDC 169957	9.5	5.6	94	19
carrots	122	FDC 170393	1.1	3.4	50	84
zucchini	196	FDC 169291	2.4	2.0	33	16
large eggs	200	FDC 171287	25.1	0.0	286	284
garlic cloves	12	FDC 169230	0.8	0.3	18	2
low-sodium soy sauce	32	FDC 172473	2.9	0.2	18	1151
toasted sesame oil	13.6	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	120	0
canola oil	14	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	124	0
toasted sesame seeds	9	FDC 170151	1.5	1.3	51	1
gochujang	38	label (E53)	1.9	1.0	89	1003

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
honey	7	FDC 169640	0.0	0.0	21	0
rice or white vinegar	15	FDC 172237	0.0	0.0	3	0
Total			158.6	29.4	2363	3072
Per serving			39.7	7.3	591	768

Kimchi fried rice with tofu and egg (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
cooked brown rice	390	FDC 169704	10.7	6.2	480	16
well-fermented kimchi	150	FDC 170392	1.6	2.4	22	747
extra-firm tofu	198	FDC 174290	19.8	2.0	164	8
large eggs	100	FDC 171287	12.6	0.0	143	142
frozen peas	134	FDC 170016	7.0	6.0	103	145
scallions	30	FDC 170005	0.5	0.8	10	5
gochujang	19	label (E53)	0.9	0.5	44	502
low-sodium soy sauce	5	FDC 172473	0.5	0.0	3	180
canola oil	14	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	124	0
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
roasted seaweed	2.5	FDC 168458	0.1	0.0	1	1
Total			53.7	18.0	1134	1745
Per serving			26.9	9.0	567	872

Cold sesame noodles with chicken and cucumber (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
whole-wheat spaghetti	280	FDC 168910	16.8	10.9	417	11
boneless	227	FDC 171077	51.1	0.0	272	102
frozen shelled edamame	78	FDC 168410	8.8	3.7	85	5
cucumber	200	FDC 168409	1.3	1.0	30	4
carrot	61	FDC 170393	0.6	1.7	25	42
tahini	30	FDC 170189	5.1	2.8	178	34
low-sodium soy sauce	16	FDC 172473	1.4	0.1	9	576
rice or white vinegar	15	FDC 172237	0.0	0.0	3	0
honey	7	FDC 169640	0.0	0.0	21	0
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
garlic clove	3	FDC 169230	0.2	0.1	4	1
toasted sesame seeds	3	FDC 170151	0.5	0.4	17	0

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
Total			85.7	20.8	1102	776
Per serving			42.9	10.4	551	388

Tuna mayo rice bowl (serves 1)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
light tuna in water	113	FDC 173709	22.0	0.0	97	279
reduced-fat mayonnaise	15	FDC 171443	0.1	0.0	54	120
cooked brown rice	146	FDC 169704	4.0	2.3	180	6
frozen shelled edamame	78	FDC 168410	8.8	3.7	85	5
diced cucumber	52	FDC 168409	0.3	0.3	8	1
scallion	15	FDC 170005	0.3	0.4	5	2
low-sodium soy sauce	5	FDC 172473	0.5	0.0	3	180
toasted sesame oil	2.3	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	20	0
roasted seaweed	2.5	FDC 168458	0.1	0.0	1	1
Total			36.0	6.8	453	594
Per serving			36.0	6.8	453	594

Chicken lettuce wraps with ssamjang (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
boneless	340	FDC 173627	66.8	0.0	411	323
low-sodium soy sauce	16	FDC 172473	1.4	0.1	9	576
honey	7	FDC 169640	0.0	0.0	21	0
grated ginger	2	FDC 169231	0.0	0.0	2	0
garlic cloves	6	FDC 169230	0.4	0.1	9	1
canola oil	4.7	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	42	0
green-leaf or romaine lettuce	200	FDC 169247	2.5	4.2	34	16
cooked brown rice	195	FDC 169704	5.3	3.1	240	8
cucumber	200	FDC 168409	1.3	1.0	30	4
carrot	61	FDC 170393	0.6	1.7	25	42
miso or Korean doenjang	17	FDC 172442	2.2	0.9	34	634
gochujang	6	label (E53)	0.3	0.2	14	158

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
toasted sesame seeds	3	FDC 170151	0.5	0.4	17	0
scallion	15	FDC 170005	0.3	0.4	5	2
Total			81.7	12.2	932	1765
Per serving			40.8	6.1	466	883

Chang's Sunday black bean noodles (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
pork loin	454	FDC 168230	97.3	0.0	649	236
chunjang	72	label (E53)	14.4	0.0	144	2304
canola oil	28	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	248	0
onion	150	FDC 170000	1.6	2.5	60	6
zucchini	196	FDC 169291	2.4	2.0	33	16
russet potato	213	FDC 170027	4.6	2.8	168	11
green cabbage	89	FDC 169975	1.1	2.2	22	16
low-sodium chicken broth	480	FDC 171609	9.6	0.0	77	144
sugar	4.2	FDC 169655	0.0	0.0	16	0
cornstarch	8	FDC 169698	0.0	0.1	30	1
whole-wheat spaghetti	560	FDC 168910	33.5	21.8	834	22
cucumber	150	FDC 168409	1.0	0.8	22	3
Total			165.6	32.2	2305	2759

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
Per serving			41.4	8.0	576	690

Beef bulgogi with broccoli and brown rice (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
top sirloin	567	FDC 174055	125.3	0.0	743	318
Asian pear	120	FDC 168177	0.6	4.3	50	0
onion	180	FDC 170000	2.0	3.1	72	7
garlic cloves	12	FDC 169230	0.8	0.3	18	2
grated ginger	6	FDC 169231	0.1	0.1	5	1
low-sodium soy sauce	48	FDC 172473	4.3	0.3	27	1727
honey	21	FDC 169640	0.1	0.0	64	1
toasted sesame oil	13.6	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	120	0
canola oil	14	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	124	0
scallions	60	FDC 170005	1.1	1.6	19	10
broccoli florets	454	FDC 170379	12.8	11.8	154	150
cooked brown rice	585	FDC 169704	16.0	9.4	720	23
toasted sesame seeds	9	FDC 170151	1.5	1.3	51	1

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
Total			164.6	32.1	2167	2239
Per serving			41.1	8.0	542	560

Mild mapo tofu with bok choy (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
firm tofu	397	FDC 172448	35.9	3.6	310	48
90% lean ground beef	227	FDC 174030	45.4	0.0	400	150
miso	17	FDC 172442	2.2	0.9	34	634
garlic cloves	9	FDC 169230	0.6	0.2	13	2
minced ginger	6	FDC 169231	0.1	0.1	5	1
low-sodium chicken broth	240	FDC 171609	4.8	0.0	38	72
low-sodium soy sauce	16	FDC 172473	1.4	0.1	9	576
cornstarch	8	FDC 169698	0.0	0.1	30	1
canola oil	14	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	124	0
red pepper flakes	0.9	FDC 170932	0.1	0.2	3	0
scallions	45	FDC 170005	0.8	1.2	14	7
bok choy	454	FDC 170390	6.8	4.5	59	295

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
cooked brown rice	585	FDC 169704	16.0	9.4	720	23
Total			114.2	20.3	1759	1808
Per serving			28.5	5.1	440	452

Soy-braised chicken with potatoes and carrots (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
boneless	680	FDC 173627	133.7	0.0	823	646
russet potatoes	454	FDC 170027	9.7	5.9	359	23
carrots	122	FDC 170393	1.1	3.4	50	84
onion	110	FDC 170000	1.2	1.9	44	4
fresh shiitake mushrooms	113	FDC 169242	2.5	2.8	38	10
garlic cloves	12	FDC 169230	0.8	0.3	18	2
minced ginger	6	FDC 169231	0.1	0.1	5	1
low-sodium soy sauce	64	FDC 172473	5.8	0.4	36	2303
honey	21	FDC 169640	0.1	0.0	64	1
water	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
scallions	30	FDC 170005	0.5	0.8	10	5

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
cooked brown rice	390	FDC 169704	10.7	6.2	480	16
Total			166.2	21.9	1966	3094
Per serving			41.6	5.5	491	774

Steamed salmon with ginger and scallion (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
salmon	283	FDC 175167	57.8	0.0	589	167
fresh ginger	22	FDC 169231	0.4	0.4	18	3
scallions	60	FDC 170005	1.1	1.6	19	10
garlic clove	3	FDC 169230	0.2	0.1	4	1
low-sodium soy sauce	16	FDC 172473	1.4	0.1	9	576
canola oil	14	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	124	0
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
baby bok choy	340	FDC 170390	5.1	3.4	44	221
cooked brown rice	293	FDC 169704	8.0	4.7	360	12
Total			74.1	10.3	1207	988
Per serving			37.0	5.1	604	494

Shrimp and egg stir-fry with peas and broccoli (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
raw shrimp	227	FDC 175179	45.6	0.0	193	270
large eggs	200	FDC 171287	25.1	0.0	286	284
frozen peas	134	FDC 170016	7.0	6.0	103	145
small broccoli florets	182	FDC 170379	5.1	4.7	62	60
cooked brown rice	195	FDC 169704	5.3	3.1	240	8
scallions	30	FDC 170005	0.5	0.8	10	5
cornstarch	2.7	FDC 169698	0.0	0.0	10	0
salt	1.5	FDC 173468	0.0	0.0	0	581
canola oil	14	FDC 172336	0.0	0.0	124	0
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
white pepper	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
Total			88.8	14.7	1067	1353
Per serving			44.4	7.3	534	677

Seaweed soup with beef and tofu (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
dried wakame seaweed	140	FDC 170496	4.2	0.7	63	1221
lean beef chuck or brisket	340	FDC 174051	75.2	0.0	449	252
firm tofu	198	FDC 172448	17.9	1.8	154	24
toasted sesame oil	13.6	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	120	0
garlic cloves	9	FDC 169230	0.6	0.2	13	2
low-sodium soy sauce	32	FDC 172473	2.9	0.2	18	1151
water	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
salt	1.5	FDC 173468	0.0	0.0	0	581
cooked brown rice	390	FDC 169704	10.7	6.2	480	16
Total			111.5	9.1	1298	3246
Per serving			27.9	2.3	324	812

Kimchi stew with pork and tofu (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
well-fermented	300	FDC 170392	3.3	4.8	45	1494
lean pork shoulder	227	FDC 168258	46.0	0.0	272	204
firm tofu	397	FDC 172448	35.9	3.6	310	48
onion	110	FDC 170000	1.2	1.9	44	4
white mushrooms	70	FDC 169251	2.2	0.7	15	4
gochujang	19	label (E53)	0.9	0.5	44	502
Korean chili flakes	1.8	FDC 170932	0.2	0.5	6	1
sugar	4.2	FDC 169655	0.0	0.0	16	0
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
water	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
scallions	30	FDC 170005	0.5	0.8	10	5
cooked brown rice	390	FDC 169704	10.7	6.2	480	16
Total			101.0	19.0	1282	2276
Per serving			25.2	4.7	320	569

Soft tofu stew with shrimp and egg (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
soft tofu	340	FDC 172449	24.4	0.7	207	27
raw shrimp	113	FDC 175179	22.7	0.0	96	134
large eggs	100	FDC 171287	12.6	0.0	143	142
kimchi	75	FDC 170392	0.8	1.2	11	374
zucchini	98	FDC 169291	1.2	1.0	17	8
onion	55	FDC 170000	0.6	0.9	22	2
garlic cloves	6	FDC 169230	0.4	0.1	9	1
Korean chili flakes	3.6	FDC 170932	0.4	1.0	11	1
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
low-sodium soy sauce	5	FDC 172473	0.5	0.0	3	180
low-sodium chicken broth	360	FDC 171609	7.2	0.0	58	108
scallion	15	FDC 170005	0.3	0.4	5	2

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
cooked brown rice	195	FDC 169704	5.3	3.1	240	8
Total			76.4	8.4	862	987
Per serving			38.2	4.2	431	494

Egg-drop soup with tofu, spinach and peas (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
low-sodium chicken broth	960	FDC 171609	19.2	0.0	154	288
soft tofu	198	FDC 172449	14.2	0.4	121	16
large eggs	150	FDC 171287	18.8	0.0	214	213
baby spinach	85	FDC 168462	2.4	1.9	20	67
frozen peas	67	FDC 170016	3.5	3.0	52	72
white mushrooms	70	FDC 169251	2.2	0.7	15	4
grated ginger	2	FDC 169231	0.0	0.0	2	0
low-sodium soy sauce	5	FDC 172473	0.5	0.0	3	180
cornstarch	8	FDC 169698	0.0	0.1	30	1
toasted sesame oil	2.3	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	20	0
scallion	15	FDC 170005	0.3	0.4	5	2
white pepper	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
Total			61.1	6.5	635	843
Per serving			30.6	3.3	318	422

Chicken, ginger and jujube soup (serves 4)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
boneless	567	FDC 173627	111.5	0.0	686	539
short-grain rice	67	FDC 168931	4.4	0.0	240	1
garlic cloves	30	FDC 169230	1.9	0.6	45	5
fresh ginger	33	FDC 169231	0.6	0.7	26	4
dried jujubes	32	FDC 168152	1.5	1.9	90	2
leek	89	FDC 169246	1.3	1.6	54	18
daikon radish	116	FDC 168451	0.7	1.9	21	24
water	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
salt	3	FDC 173468	0.0	0.0	0	1163
scallions	45	FDC 170005	0.8	1.2	14	7
black pepper	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
Total			122.7	7.8	1177	1762
Per serving			30.7	2.0	294	441

Warm edamame with sesame and chili (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
frozen shelled edamame	233	FDC 168411	27.8	12.1	282	14
toasted sesame oil	2.3	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	20	0
flaky or coarse salt	1.2	FDC 173468	0.0	0.0	0	465
red pepper flakes	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
Total			27.8	12.1	302	479
Per serving			13.9	6.1	151	240

Soy-braised eggs (serves 3)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
large eggs	300	FDC 171287	37.7	0.0	429	426
low-sodium soy sauce	48	FDC 172473	4.3	0.3	27	1727
water	0	not counted	0.0	0.0	0	0
honey	21	FDC 169640	0.1	0.0	64	1
garlic cloves	12	FDC 169230	0.8	0.3	18	2
Total			42.9	0.6	538	2156
Per serving			14.3	0.2	179	719

Chilled tofu with scallion-soy sauce (serves 2)

Ingredient	Grams	Source ID	Protein g	Fiber g	kcal	Sodium mg
soft tofu	397	FDC 172449	28.5	0.8	242	32
low-sodium soy sauce	16	FDC 172473	1.4	0.1	9	576
rice or white vinegar	5	FDC 172237	0.0	0.0	1	0
toasted sesame oil	4.5	FDC 171016	0.0	0.0	40	0
scallion	15	FDC 170005	0.3	0.4	5	2
toasted sesame seeds	3	FDC 170151	0.5	0.4	17	0
Korean chili flakes	0.9	FDC 170932	0.1	0.2	3	0
diced cucumber	52	FDC 168409	0.3	0.3	8	1
Total			31.1	2.2	324	612
Per serving			15.6	1.1	162	306

Where the numbers come from

Every number and health statement in this book traces to one of the entries below. They are the same evidence IDs our whole team uses (EVIDENCE.md). Grade A means a Cochrane review, a large meta-analysis or a guideline body. B means a single good trial or a small meta-analysis. C means an observational study: it shows a link, not cause and effect. D means lab, physiology or label data.

E19 (grade A– (meta)). Voluntary slow breathing (around 6 breaths/min) increases vagally-mediated heart-rate variability during and after practice.

Source: Laborde et al., Neurosci Biobehav Rev 2022 — <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0149763422002007>

E20 (grade A). Exercise and resting BP: 270 RCTs, 15,827 people. Isometric training lowered BP the most (–8.24/–4.00 mmHg). Wall squat ranked top for systolic. Aerobic –4.49/–2.53, dynamic resistance –4.55/–3.04. These are average changes over weeks of training, not instant.

Source: Edwards et al., BJSM 2023 — <https://bmjgroup.com/static-isometric-exercise-such-as-wall-sits-best-for-lowering-blood-pressure/>

E23 (grade A– (meta)). Light walking after meals (even 2–5 minutes) lowers the post-meal glucose rise compared with sitting.

Source: Buffey et al., Sports Med 2022 — <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/35147898/>

E24 (grade A (meta of cohorts + RCTs)). Fiber: 25–29 g/day was linked with 15–30% lower all-cause and CV mortality, type 2 diabetes and colorectal cancer. More fiber was linked with more benefit.

Source: Reynolds et al., Lancet 2019 — [https://www.thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736\(18\)31809-9/fulltext](https://www.thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736(18)31809-9/fulltext)

E25 (grade B (exploratory)). Chronic constipation: 2 green kiwifruit/day vs 100 g prunes vs 12 g psyllium, 4 weeks, 75 patients. All three improved bowel movements similarly. Kiwi had the fewest side effects and highest satisfaction, and improved bloating.

Source: Chey et al., Am J Gastroenterol 2021 — <https://www.healio.com/news/gastroenterology/20210608/kiwi-fruit-effectively-relieves-symptoms-in-chronic-constipation>

E26 (grade B (small)). 36 adults, 10 weeks. A high-fermented-food diet (yogurt, kefir, kimchi, sauerkraut, kombucha; intake rose to about 6 servings/day by the end) increased microbiome diversity and lowered 19 inflammatory proteins (including IL-6). The high-fiber arm didn't show those changes over 10 weeks.

Source: Wastyk et al., Cell 2021 — <https://med.stanford.edu/news/all-news/2021/07/fermented-food-diet-increases-microbiome-diversity-lowers-inflammation.html>

E27 (grade B). Prune Study: postmenopausal women eating 50 g prunes/day (about 5–6) preserved total hip BMD over 12 months vs controls.

Source: De Souza et al., Am J Clin Nutr 2022 — <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9193411/>

E28 (grade A (consensus)). PROT-AGE: adults over 65 should get 1.0–1.2 g protein/kg/day, and 1.2–1.5 g/kg if active or ill (unless there is severe kidney disease). Aim for 25–30 g per meal with about 2.5–2.8 g leucine.

Source: Bauer et al., JAMDA 2013 — <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23867520/>

E30 (grade A). Exercise for chronic low back pain: 249 trials, 24,486 people. Pain about 15 points better (0–100 scale) at 3 months vs no treatment or usual care. Function improved modestly.

Source: Hayden et al., Cochrane 2021 — https://www.cochrane.org/evidence/CD009790_exercise-treatment-chronic-low-back-pain

E32 (grade A–). Honey improved upper-respiratory-infection symptoms, especially cough frequency and severity, compared with usual care. Never give honey to infants under 12 months.

Source: Abuelgasim et al., BMJ Evid Based Med 2021 — <https://www.phc.ox.ac.uk/news/honey-better-than-usual-care-for-easing-respiratory-symptoms-especially-cough>

E33 (grade A–). Ginger for osteoarthritis pain: small effect vs placebo, with more GI complaints. Say it "may help a little". Ginger for nausea has reasonable support. It can interact with blood thinners at supplement doses.

Source: Bartels et al., Osteoarthritis Cartilage 2015 — [https://www.oarsijournal.com/article/S1063-4584\(14\)00641-4/fulltext](https://www.oarsijournal.com/article/S1063-4584(14)00641-4/fulltext) ; ginger umbrella review AJCN 2022 — [https://ajcn.nutrition.org/article/S0002-9165\(22\)00277-5/fulltext](https://ajcn.nutrition.org/article/S0002-9165(22)00277-5/fulltext)

E34 (grade A–). Enteric-coated peppermint oil improved global IBS symptoms and abdominal pain vs placebo. It can worsen reflux.

Source: Alammari et al., BMC Complement Altern Med 2019 — <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1186/s12906-018-2409-0>

E35 (grade B+). Salt substitute (25% potassium chloride) in 20,995 older adults at high risk: stroke, major CV events and death were all reduced. Caution: potassium salt isn't for people with kidney disease or on potassium-raising medicines. Always say "ask your doctor first".

Source: Neal et al., NEJM 2021 (SSaSS) — <https://www.nejm.org/doi/full/10.1056/NEJMoa2105675>

E52 (grade A (reference database)). USDA FoodData Central, SR Legacy (April 2018 release): per-100 g energy, protein, total dietary fiber, sodium and leucine used for every recipe calculation in Sun Yoon's Strong Kitchen (FDC IDs listed per ingredient in the book's method appendix).

Source: Opened/downloaded https://fdc.nal.usda.gov/fdc-datasets/FoodData_Central_sr_legacy_food_csv_2018-04.zip

E53 (grade D (label data)). Label values for two Korean pastes not in SR Legacy, per 100 g: Sempio gochujang (barcode 8801005000178) 233 kcal, 5.0 g protein, 2.7 g fiber, 2,640 mg sodium; Obok chunjang (8801126032447) 200 kcal, 20 g protein, 0 g fiber, 3,200 mg sodium (single crowd-sourced label; protein looks high, so treat as approximate).

Source: Open Food Facts API — opened <https://world.openfoodfacts.org/product/8801005000178> , <https://world.openfoodfacts.org/product/8801126032447>

E54 (grade A (federal guidance)). Safe minimum internal temperatures: ground meat 160°F; beef/pork steaks, chops, roasts 145°F + 3-minute rest; all poultry 165°F; fish 145°F or until opaque and flaking; shrimp until pearly/opaque; clams until shells open; eggs until yolk and white are firm; egg dishes 160°F; leftovers 165°F.

Source: FoodSafety.gov — opened <https://www.foodsafety.gov/food-safety-charts/safe-minimum-internal-temperatures>

E55 (grade A (federal guidance)). Adults 65+ are at higher risk of foodborne illness (weaker immune response, slower gut transit, less stomach acid, reduced liver and kidney clearance).

Source: FoodSafety.gov — opened <https://www.foodsafety.gov/people-at-risk/older-adults>

E56 (grade B– (single RCT, unblinded)). Water gargling RCT (Japan): 387 healthy volunteers aged 18–65, 60 days. Gargling plain water daily was linked with 36% fewer upper-respiratory infections vs usual care; povidone-iodine gargle showed no significant difference. No sham/placebo arm (critics note possible bias). Not studied in adults over 65.

Source: Satomura et al., Am J Prev Med 2005 (primary abstract page returned 403: primary not opened, unverified). Opened secondary report: <https://www.infectioncontroltoday.com/view/gargling-may-prevent-colds-expert-finds-results-hard-swallow>

E57 (grade D (in vitro)). Chicken soup slowed white-blood-cell (neutrophil) movement in a lab dish. The authors state clinical benefit "remains untested". Lab evidence only: tradition, enjoy it as food.

Source: Rennard et al., Chest 2000 — opened <https://www.unmc.edu/strategic-communications/for-the-media/press-kits/files/chickensouppublishedstudy2000.pdf>

E58 (grade A (NIH fact sheet)). Seaweed iodine varies enormously: commercially available seaweeds measured 16 to 2,984 mcg iodine per gram. Adult upper limit 1,100 mcg/day from all sources. People with autoimmune thyroid disease may have adverse effects at intakes considered safe for others.

Source: NIH Office of Dietary Supplements — opened <https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Iodine-HealthProfessional/> , <https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/Iodine-Consumer/>